

the floating liars' club

november 2002

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Hindu
Love
Garden



nathan mcknight - ben criles - shannon rampe - joe belfony

Dear Readers,

How delightful it feels composing this letter to you this chilled night in late October. So is the pleasure of sharing with you our second installment of the Floating Liars' Club, an attempt at creating another desirable outlet for writers here in Central Ohio. Thus far, we've been successful: selling out our first run of the October issue (roughly 100 issues) in a little more than two weeks. We also branched out to Michael Chabon, Pulitzer Prize winning author of *The Amazing Adventures of Kavalier and Klay*. Funny story, really. After his lecture on the genesis of his award-winning novel Oct. 14, we stood in line with the October issue of FLC bagged like a comic book and slapped it on the table in front of him. Yes, he was expecting it to be one of his novels, but we shilled the magazine instead of going off on some insipid tangent about what his work means to us. Had there been another agenda, I would have been more sentimental, telling Mr. Chabon that I read the book drifting in a scratched Starcraft on the Ottawa River in Northern Ontario; some of it in front of a fireplace with an old blind dog's head nestled on my lap. Do you guys levitate, he asked. Yes, we do. But I digress.

Thursday nights we've been appearing at Larry's on High Street via a magic carpet. We also have copies on sale at Monkey's Retreat, Magnolia Thunderpussy, Used Kids Records and the Wexner Center for the Arts. I think FLC has a nice pulp feel to it, similar to the *Weird Tales* or *Asimov* readers you may have found in your grandparent's basements. But we're not genre specific. I feel we offer an eclectic mix of style, subject matters and diversified voices. Joe Bellomy has done the artwork on both issues, much to our satisfaction--the colors of this issue's cover art are quite compelling--I should add. This time he trades his pencil for ink. We've discussed changing the art format each month, as we've discussed many ideas for the magazine, which really is our pet project right now. We'll experiment with each issue, exploring what we can achieve. This issue will be officially kicked

off at a reading the first of the month at Victorian's Midnight Café. Although this comes after the fact, we anticipate similar activities each month, including a booth, we hope, set up at the Gallery Hop.

It's our romantic vision to see people lost in this magazine at a bar, on a bench waiting for a bus, or to see it tented beside toilets and on nightstands. We need your help in making this effort a viable one. Please submit us your stories, poems or artwork via e-mail at floatingliarsclub@hotmail.com. Our submissions deadline for the December issue is Tuesday, Nov. 19. We'll consider all submissions. We're particularly interested in having a strong female presence in the magazine, which the magazine so far, I've been told, is brimming with testosterone. Should you be a reader and not a writer, we encourage your comments at the aforementioned e-mail address, regardless. We want your feedback. Let yourself be heard.

It requires great dedication to put together something of this quality in the breaks between working 40-plus hours a week, maintaining relationships, and sometimes eating and sleeping. We will make the necessary improvements, I promise you. We occasionally beam at our end product, but only for a few glaring moments before shifting our focus to the following month's issue. The FLC meets every week in the confines of Eveningland Publications, a smoky room on King Avenue, where games of chess are had, Coca-cola and dark beers are drank and these stories are workshopped.

Thematically, this issue is connected with characters that seek change to the routines of their lives, but don't seem to have the wherewithal to create that change alone--see Timothy, A Cover Letter, The Recovery of Sunken Vessels and The Dreams of a Sleeping Lion. The idea for Sleeping Lion first spawned at a Kroger's express checkout in Bowling Green, Ohio circa Fall of 1998. I busied myself with a tabloid as the woman ahead of me fished for the errant pennies spilled in her purse. The cover featured this faux Nostradamus squinting suspiciously over a crystal ball and its headline read: "The Spring Winds of 1999 Will Carry the Voice of God." I knew within those words was the matter

for a story. It took nearly four years and three or four takes before I got it down. Maybe, I haven't yet. My gut tells me it's right, though. I love how the idea for a story lives in the subconscious until you get it down. This one was with me as I drove by fields of stubble, past an accident on the interstate, and with me as I reveled at the impossible synchronicity of my turn signal with that of the car in front of me at traffic lights. It's true what Chabon said about writing being porous. When you're looking for what's needed in a story, it does often find you. That's why many pivotal scenes and moments have been written on the back of ATM receipts or junk mail. The spring winds of 1999 carried JFK Jr. into the murky Atlantic Ocean off of Martha's Vinyard. Is that the Voice of God? If there is a creator in some form, haven't the Kennedy's pissed them off something awful?

Nathan McKnight, a geologist and expert rat trainer at COSI, has written an intriguing story on the circularity of life, one that is reminiscent of Clarke's 2001: A Space Odyssey in some ways. It too has an element of recovery as the Memory of Flesh is looking for its home planet. Claire, in McKnight's Elders in the Love Garden, finds herself huddling up to a wax figure of Mrs. Hoover while pining for her grandmother. Joe Bellomy's Concrete Afternoon, laden with deft detail and imagery, tells the recollection of a girl's experience with a cult. Shannon Rampe--in what may be one of the more disturbing scenes I've read in a while--accurately captures the school bus experience and adds more depth to the already gloomy yellow mass. A man tells what went wrong with his life--why the bear magnets have migrated to another refrigerator--to an unsuspecting editor in Rampe's A Cover Letter, where style is truly an extension of format. I hope you enjoy this second batch of stories, as much as I've enjoyed watching them blossom, and continue to support our cause.

Stay with us and we'll keep you afloat.

Ben Crites
October 2002

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november 2002

For the

ELDERS IN THE LOVE GARDEN

by
Nathan McKnight



I.

Claire was thinking about Gramma again when the wax iron thumped on the floor and Grampa Lyssie shrieked like a boy a tenth his age.

"Clairebell you know you got to hand it to me the other way hon!" She tensed at seeing him rock in his work chair, rubbing the scorched palm and inspecting it with eyes shrouded in deep wells of puffy skin.

"Oh Grampa, I'm so sorry!" She felt the corners of her eyes moisten vicariously.

Tiny specks of wax stippled his cheeks and arms.

"Now don't you cry honey. Pappy's okay. You just gotta be more careful, that's all. Shoot!" Grampa glanced down. They'd both forgotten about the fallen instrument. He grabbed the wax iron just too late to keep it from melting a divot in the rosewood linoleum. He laid it gingerly on one of the asbestos plates that surfaced the workbench. He put

his hand on Claire's shoulder. "You take care of the harem there and put a little rouge on Vishnu while I go dress my hand." Claire nodded, lip between teeth. She took the make-up tray and picked her way among the girls of the scene.

The Hindu Love Garden was Grampa's newest creation. He talked like it was going to bring half the state into the little museum. A fine piece, he called it. He would beam at the sequined velvet robes and say those words at least twice a day, assuring Claire not to worry too much about the animal strangeness of the wax faces. People would pay good money to see that kind of thing these days, he said. Tutenkhamon just ain't good enough for people no more, he told her.

Claire pulled an ottoman up to the standing figure, thinking maybe she had coated the rouge brush too heavily. She figured that Vishnu was supposed to be a boy. After all, even the

heaped-on necklaces and scarves didn't obscure an obviously flat and curly-haired bosom. However, the extra blush and long eyelashes made her wonder. That, and the fact that the face was so delicate, even pretty—despite its blueness. She stared into the glossy black eyeballs, trying to resolve the matter in her head while she blushed him up.

The harem had been easier work than Vishnu, though she had to try several shades before choosing a deep burgundy that stood out against the tawny wax. She went back to the harem after she finished Vishnu and painted glossy, puce lipstick on thickly. She thought she might like that color for herself one day. Moving back and forth from the workbench, first with blush, then lipstick, then finally with eye shadow, she was extra careful not to disturb anything she wasn't supposed to.

Her work was a dance of perfection, arranging the scene for maximum effect. Sometimes though, she came precariously close to toppling the crowded harem like the apprentice plate-spinners at Verona's, and it frightened Claire to think that her clumsiness might cost Grampa several weeks worth of work, not to mention his health. Grampa seemed more frail than the wax figures and anything she did to them she may as well be doing to him. But it couldn't be helped—Claire had to finish it.

Grampa came back into the room. "Careful there," he said. "We might just get more business than the Verona Fun Park with this one."

Claire hoped this exhibit would do some good for Grampa's health. After last summer, she knew a bad exhibit could certainly do him harm. Last summer when the regional Shriner convention was crowding the aisles and spilling out onto the stone walk and the sun had softened the wax of the French Revolution display, the neck under the guillotine melted and the Marquis's head fell off into its long-waiting basket. The crowd was more than amused, but Grampa fell down flat like he'd been the one executed. Turned out he had a heart attack. A little bite, he called it. He said his old heart couldn't bear that kind of stress, not on one of the most important days of that year.

II.

The light of dusk filtered into the yard through the trees on the ridge. Claire wedged herself into the bay window by the porch and reread Gramma Adie's letter. The hand that wrote it was visibly rheumatic. The d's and t's were gangly and the s's were pinched, telling more about Gramma's condition than the words themselves. Claire's memory of her grandmother had faded in the last two years. She had trouble holding the image in her head. She could clearly see an ever-twitching cheek and she could hear the old woman cough, but Claire had to struggle to remember what color her eyes were. She didn't even remember whether she had glasses or not.

Before she got the TB, Gramma Adie had gone to Missouri to help out her eldest granddaughter—Claire's cousin Joann. The divorce happened shortly after that when Gramma found a Northern man who promised to take care of her. Claire thought that was nice of the Northerner, but Grampa had a lot of words for the man, even though he and Gramma busted up pretty quick. Now, Gramma was back in Joann's house and Joann still had plenty of trouble with her two kids to worry about a sickly old woman.

Gramma had always had lung problems, but this was the first time she'd mentioned them in a letter. Joann and the boys are helping me out loads, she wrote, I'd be dead already without them.

Grampa's old typewriter sat in the hallway between the house and the museum. She typed in near darkness, the only light shining in from Grampa's workshop, where he was molding the limbs for Shiva. Grampa hadn't used his typewriter since he'd stopped replying to Gramma's letters. On account of his nearsightedness, she didn't have to worry about Grampa seeing what she wrote. Claire tried to imagine what Grampa would say if he knew Gramma Adie was sick.

Adie honey, she wrote, I know you're sick but my poor heart still hurts so much that I can't bear to see your face. I believe you'll be better real soon. I believe I will come see you when I can think about your pretty face without crying. Maybe I'll send Clairebell up to see you when the weather clears. Love, Ulysses. Claire looked over her work, trying to hear Grampa's voice saying the words.

When she Grampa shut the light off in his workshop, Claire followed him into the kitchen. The glass pane of the window where she'd been sitting left a cold section on her back. She leaned against the refrigerator's side, always warm. Grampa Lyssie was pouring bourbon into an empty tomato puree can. The label was yellowing and beginning to peel around the edges, but was otherwise well-preserved.

"Grampa..." He looked at the letter in her hand, frowning. "Pappy... Can I sleep in the Lincoln Bedroom tonight?"

"I suppose. But if you get chilly, you crawl into bed with Pappy. It's a mighty cold evening tonight, it is."

Claire turned the thermostat in the museum lobby up by a few degrees, though Grampa had repeatedly warned her about melting the wax. The Lincoln Room was quite chilly but the little bed was cozy and just her size. Lou Henry Hoover stood with her rock collection next to the footboard, inviting guests into the room. Claire fell asleep staring at the back of the First Lady's head by moonlight.

Grampa got a call the next morning. The way he was getting excited on the phone, Claire supposed it was a big



job—maybe something for the Veronas. She didn't want to ruin his excitement, but she'd been steeling her nerves for this all morning, gotten up early and stared in the mirror, practicing a determined head-tilt until Grampa woke up. But that phone call came and now she felt unsteady. She stole past the Elder Statesmen's Room, greatly less amused than usual that the old men were all about her size.

"Grampa," she said, "can I..."

"Not right now, honey, whatever it is. I have to go." Grampa Lyssie was grinning like the wax Valentino lying on the rack behind him. "Reverend Woods says he might have some work for me." He threw on his corduroy jacket and started out the door.

"But Grampa..."

Grampa looked back, squatted down—still smiling, but now his lips twisted to one side. "What's wrong Clairebell?"

"I... well, I was hoping maybe I could visit Gramma sometime."

The twisted smile became a grimace, hurt and confused. "Now, why you wanna go and do that? She ain't never took the time to come here and visit you."

"But I haven't seen her in so long, Pappy. Please."

"Why you wanna see that old bag? She ain't even wrote you." Claire knew that was a lie. She'd fished a dozen letters out of the trash and all of them asked about her. Sometimes, she even sent a dried leaf or a Canadian penny as a gift to Claire. Grampa Lyssie's lower lip turned down, pulling the upper lip with it which in turn pulled his nose downward, drawing his whole face into a frown.

Claire nodded, but added "What if she's sick, Pappy."

Claire hoped to uncover a hint of sympathy. The result was confusing at first. Grampa turned his head, trying to choke back a sob. Claire put a hand over her mouth as if to stop the words even though they'd already come out. Grampa started bawling, his squat turned into rocking. She hugged him, and let her tears wet his suede-covered shoulders.

"Clairebell, she's trying to take you from me don't you see? She took my heart and soul, and now she's trying to take my only care in the world. Clairebell, you know you're my life." He wiped his tears, but Claire didn't wipe hers.

Grampa came back from Reverend Woods's house, wringing his hands. He sat out some onion leaf tracing paper and started digging through the stack of Saturday Evening Posts next to the fridge. Claire watched silently, waiting to be given a task. He fumbled through the pages of a few until he found what he was looking for: a picture of an exotic-looking woman in leopard print pants.

"A Mr. Ackerman from the Ohio Governor's Council is staying in town for a couple of days. Reverend Woods told him about the museum and he's gonna visit. Woods says he's working with the World's Fair to build a futuristic exhibit with rockets and space stuff. If he likes the place here, I might get hired to do the waxwork. Can you imagine! Making an exhibit for the World's Fair! Right here in Gatlinburg!"

He whittled a sharp point onto the square pencil he kept behind his ear and doodled a pair of antennae onto the woman in the magazine. Grampa crooked his neck for a long moment and looked into Claire's face.

"I think we can get this deal on the strength of the new exhibit. But we gotta spend all day tomorrow working. Still gotta set the jewels and dress Shiva, not to mention the rings on all them fingers! I need your expert hand with the make-up hon. Oh, and I forgot about the nose rings!" Grampa Lyssie laid the tracing paper over the magazine and began to sketch out a scene featuring the woman and a bunch of little elflike creatures with matching antennae.

"I'll go down to the Green Store and get the rings if you want," said Claire

"Are you sure, hon? It's almost a mile." Claire nodded, and after a moments reflection Grampa said, "I'll tell you what. Why don't I give you some money and you can pick me up some rings—get the cheap ones, but only if you can find them in gold...the nose rings that is; the finger rings can be whatever—and I'll throw in an extra nickel for candy. Oh, and get some more scarf material too—and some sugar cane wax. And see if Mrs. Stieger'll put in an order for half a pound of ozokerite."

Grampa Lyssie handed her a five note and went back to scratching lines on the onion leaf paper. "Bye-bye Claire, hurry back hon."

"Bye, Grampa." She stared down at the bill as she left through the back.

The back room housed the Saponofied Iroquois Princess—a girl turned to soap. The brass placard said that she died two hundred years ago from heartbreak when her lover, a Hessian general, left her to sail the high seas. She never asked Grampa Lyssie if she was real or if he'd molded her dark, splotchy skin with his own hands. It didn't look like Grampa's work, though. Grampa always worked hard to make his figures attractive. So did Claire, for that matter.

The walk down to the Green Store wasn't so bad, except that she didn't have anything to wear that was quite warm enough. She wondered if a girl could really turn to soap out of heartbreak, the pain stilling her flesh from the outside in. She wondered what the weather was like in Jackson City right now. She wondered whether the five note would get her all the way to Missouri, but frowned at the thought of making Grampa Lyssie cry again. Anyhow, it was probably snowy and icy. Somehow, the thought didn't make her feel any warmer now. A chilly breeze came down from the mountains to fight with the dirty wafts of heat thrown off by buildings and automobiles in town. Here, in a gully she used as a shortcut past the curling driveway, the cold won out and chewed at her soul under the trees that shadowed an already overcast afternoon. As she made her way downwards, the heat began displacing the cold. By the time the ground leveled she was feeling almost cheerful and she started planning her next letter to Gramma in her head.

The store's gravel lot spread rough-edged across the muddy road; white-rocked and new, it caught what little sunlight there was. On the other side of the road, it became the lot for the Rough Rider Saloon. On the saloon side, there were a few dusty cars but the big, green general store only had Mrs. Stieger's rusty Buick.

"Young lady, where is your grandfather?" Mrs. Stieger's son, Oscar scowled at Claire as he tugged a jangling set of keys out of his back pocket.

"He sent me down to order some ozokerite and get some things."

"Well, you'll have to wait until tomorrow. My mother will have to do any ordering."

"Can't I at least..."

"No lip now, girl. I'm closing up. Tell Ulysses that he shouldn't let you run around on your own these days. Town's becoming a madhouse." Oscar latched the glass doors together and flipped through the keys until he found the one with the Buick logo. He seemed surprised when he looked up and Claire was still standing in the parking lot. He deepened the frown lines around his mouth for a while, then his expression melted and smoothed. "Here now, why don't I give you a ride home honey?"

Oscar had Claire climb in the backseat because he had to pick up the reverend on the way. They went a long way up the hill before coming on a little shack in the woods. It was starting to darken and firelight glowed in the single window. Shadows were tossed across the walls. Oscar honked his horn to get their attention. Reverend Woods backed out the door after a time, clasping the hands of an old lady, and alternating his head between a bow and a back-and-forth swing, as if trying to duck away and express deep condolences at the same time.

When he got in the car, the two men conversed as though Claire wasn't sitting in the backseat. Oscar was grim, but the reverend, always animated, made light of the situation—apparently, the del Mar boy shot up the saloon this morning and then turned the gun on himself. Popped himself like a Coke bottle, said the reverend as he flicked a thumb in his cheek to illustrate the sound.

"Leave it to a Methodist to ruin a good bar fight," Reverend Woods waved a hand over his head. "Now take Ulysses McCabe, there's a fightin' man..."

Reverend Woods was interrupted by a loud cough and a head-jerk from Oscar.

"Why did Mrs. del Mar's son kill himself?"

"Claire, I think that's rightly between Leroy and the Lord. Everybody's got to die sometime, and I guess this morning was Leroy del Mar's time to go."

"Then why's everybody so sad? Because he shot up the saloon?"

"Well, that's part of it. But it's mainly because he hasn't been getting along with his mother for months. Poor thing never even got to say goodbye." He shook his head and continued, "See Claire, it's not the way you die that's important. It's how you leave things when you go. And, of course everybody's afraid to die. That's a big part of why people get sad when their friends die; they're reminded that it's gonna be them one of these days."

He said that it was his job to make people less sad when somebody dies. That's what he was going to see Mrs. Stieger for: she was one of Leroy's best pals.

"I'm not afraid to die," she whispered to herself.

By the time Oscar dropped her off at the bottom of the drive, the sun was down and the porch light was on. Grampa was still working, and he said not to worry about the supplies.

He'd go to the store in the morning. Claire didn't remind him that she still

had the five dollars in her pocket.

III.

That Thursday had been one of the longest days she could remember. Grampa went down to the store and left her alone to work on the Love Garden. She thought she'd learned more about make-up that day than in the other eight years of her life combined.

Grampa went to bed early since he'd stayed up all through the previous night. He'd worn his good clothes to bed so he wouldn't have to rush and change in the morning. She hoped that didn't mean he'd be getting up early this morning too. He had left her to finish putting the rings on Vishnu and Shiva. Instead, she pulled the suit off president Jefferson in the Hall of Elder Statesmen.

It took most of her will to stay up the night. When the first lights of dawn made dust motes sparkle in the air, she stood on the bed and kissed Mrs. Hoover's lightly rouged,



waxen cheek. Then, she daubed rouge delicately on her own cheeks and painted her lips pink and glossy and left the Lincoln bedroom.

She'd had difficulty managing it, but she got Thomas Jefferson out of the crowd, barely having to move John Hancock and William Penn. Jefferson's suit was the nicest of them all, with velvet lapels and satin trim. Jefferson was also the only one there who didn't have a waistline bigger than her outstretched arms. Now, she put the suit on herself and tucked the money Grampa had given her for the rings and candy into the inside pocket. She wondered if Jefferson ever really needed to hide anything like she did. The little figure of the president lay on the floor, looking unready for his final placement. Claire lugged the former president out into the newer section of the museum.

She finished her work and closed the black velvet curtains just like Grampa had them, ready for unveiling. She packed some snacks from the fridge and left the museum, locking the door carefully behind her. Grampa had left a sign on the front door for Mr. Ackerman expecting that he wouldn't wake up before the Ohio gentleman arrived.

8 *Please ring the doorbell,* it said.

On the way down the gully, she ate a sickly sweet fig and molasses bar.

IV.

The train station was already busy at this early hour and she had to wait in line behind drowsy strangers to get her ticket. She told the attendant she was going to Jackson City.

"I'm sorry honey," said the gray-haired lady behind the counter, "but you're twenty cents short."

Claire stared down at the five-dollar-bill and felt her chin begin to twitch and her eyes tear up.

"Gramma," she said, sobbing.

"Are you traveling with your grandmother, dear?"

Claire shook her head and between little gasps for air, she told the grandmotherly lady that she was going to visit her Gramma Adie. She wiped her eyes on the stiff jacket and felt her skin prickle, turning to buttery soap.

"Oh, honey don't cry. It's okay. I'll tell you what—why don't you give me the five, and we'll call it even."

Claire watched the Tennessee mountains rise and fall and become mists, and finally stretch out into flatness. She remembered Grampa's heart attack. A heart attack: Claire hoped that's how it happened to her, all dramatic like a fun park play. If she was gonna have to leave this Earth, she imagined it should be a big event, something that would make Reverend Woods nod and say, Yup she sure kicked the bucket she did. Grace be to God, rest her pretty little soul. Claire lay down and dreamed of Gramma.

V.

Claire stood up from the glossy, black bench of the caboose. The wet Missouri air was uncomfortable to breath, but carried the sweet odor of mulch.

"I can't believe you're here, honey. How's Ulysses doing? Still doting on that old shack of a museum of his?" Gramma Adie's skin had a gray tinge under the cheeks. Her lips were gaudy crimson and the beehive wig she wore almost matched the sky.

Claire tried not to scratch, knowing that her skin would turn pink and she wouldn't look pretty for Gramma. The felt suit Claire took from Mr. Jefferson made her skin itch all over. She tried not to think about the naked president she'd left kissing Vishnu.

Gramma Adie coughed and took Claire's hand.

"Gramma," said Claire, "I have to tell you something. You know those letters? All those nice letters Grampa wrote you? I—well, I wrote them."

"I know dear. Lyssie'll come around. In the meantime though, you're the best granddaughter a woman could ever have."



TWO SKIRMISHES

IN THE NEVER-ENDING WAR

IN RURAL OHIO



by
Shannon Rampe

It was the third of May 1989. It was a hard day, the heat unrelenting, the air still as ashes, and all the kids aching for the end of the year. Tempers and temperatures were high. The engine of the school bus ran hot that day, it was due for an oil change and was low on coolant. Sheila, the bus driver that year, had already yelled at three different kids before the fifth stop. Ordinarily she could shut those kids up for an entire ride with a single word, but not that day.

The faded yellow bus turned onto Greely Chapel road and waves of heat blossomed off the asphalt. The engine chugged one last time, like the cough of a dying man, and stalled. The bus coasted to a halt in between two fields, one with young corn and the other with little sprouts that might have become beans but were already yellowing in the heat. White steam billowed out from under the hood. As Sheila climbed off she gave one menacing look back at the kids, particularly at a group of boys arguing over a stolen baseball card. She lifted the hood and a cloud of scalding steam gassed her. She climbed back on a moment later, holding her right hand in her left and gritting her teeth. Angry blisters swelled on her palm.

She fumbled for the CB with her left hand, but after a moment of clicking it on and off she gave up. The thing was dead. She cursed then, the only time she ever said anything other than "damn" or "hell" in front of those kids, and for a minute that shut them up. The whole lot of them stared at her wide-eyed. "Alright," she told them, "the engine is done and the CB is out. There's a house about a half-mile from here, and I gotta walk down there and make a call to the garage. They'll send us out another bus." Some of the kids argued, some whined about the heat and the crappy bus. Sheila slapped the dashboard. "Goddammit, shut the hell up! Now I'm going to be back in ten minutes and I don't want any malarkey going

on while I'm gone. I want every one of you to sit here, be quiet, and keep your paws off each other. No fighting, no bickering, and no climbing over the seats like monkeys." She stepped down off the bus and started up the road, wiping a film of sweat from her brow.

Andrew Spikott was the real troublemaker that year and by no means was this day any exception. He was only a freshman, but was eighteen years old. He had been held back a couple of times and had a mouth like the Grand Canyon, and the common sense and intelligence of a dried up mud puddle. He always went by Drew, and behind his back the other kids called him Drool, because he had a bad habit of leaving his mouth hanging open and, inevitably, a wet spot pooled on his t-shirt. The kid smelled bad and the older kids didn't want anything to do with him so he didn't really have any friends. He'd intimidate the younger kids though, pushing them around, giving them "wet willies" or flicking their ears. A couple of junior high kids named Tom and Robby were his lackeys, and between the two of them they were almost as mean as Drew himself.

Drew was really irked that day. He was sweating hard. Between his weight and the blue jeans and cowboy boots, he was drenched and he smelled like a locker room. He'd been laying the pressure on Brad Michaelson all week to steal him a Chris Sabo rookie baseball card from Nathan Hoffstedder, and had threatened to beat the snot out of him if he didn't do it. His tactics varied from wheedling to outright threats, and finally, shortly before the bus stalled, Brad had moved up a few seats to trade cards with Nathan. When Nathan wasn't watching, Brad pulled the card out of the page of plastic sleeves and slipped it into his shirt pocket. He was sweating almost as hard as Drew and his hand shook as he passed the binder full of cards back to Nathan. "Nothing I need right now," he mumbled, and scurried back to his seat.

As the engine ground to a halt Nathan turned around in his seat. His eyes were hot behind his wire-rim glasses. "Who took my Sabo card?" he asked, his voice hot and gravelly. "Brad, do you have my Sabo? Drew?"

Brad refused to look him in the eye, just muttered, "Nope," and turned his attention to a stalk of corn in the field.

Several other kids turned around to watch the altercation. One girl, Wendy Mulligan, watched all of this with a kind of fascination. She was new—it was only her third day here—and she hadn't made any friends. Her family had recently moved to Lima and she'd been transferred from a private to a public school. The never-ending war on the school bus was an entirely new experience for her.

"You calling me a thief Hoffstedder?" shouted Drew. He climbed to his feet, letting his belly press against the top of the seat.

Nathan fumed for a moment but said nothing. Drew was five years older than Nathan and twice his size. Sheila climbed off the bus at this point and Nathan flipped through

his binder again, holding up the page with its empty corner sleeve. "Come on guys, just give it back. Who took it?"

"Eat me you little dickwad," Drew said. "I don't have your shitty card. You probably lost it in your fat ass!" Tom and Robby cracked up despite the fact that they both weighed a good forty pounds more than Nathan did and Drew weighed more than either of them.

Nathan's cheeks flushed and he pushed his black bangs away from his glasses. He stared in silence for a few minutes before turning back to Brad. "Hey man, you don't have my card, do you?"

Brad avoided his gaze again, trying to find anything else to look at. "No dude, why would I want a Sabo card? I don't even like the Reds."

"But you were just looking at it a minute ago. Are you sure you didn't take it by accident?"

Brad shook his head. His face looked a little green at this point. He pressed his clammy palms against the green vinyl seat and tried to find anything to look at other than the horde of faces staring at him. Wendy caught his eye and for a moment he didn't turn away. He had noticed her, of course, all the kids were talking about the new girl. She was a year older than him, a freshman in high school, and she was pretty in a plain sort of way. She wore wire rim glasses and had long, straight hair. It was auburn and matched her inquisitive eyes. Brad chewed his lip and looked again at the stalks of corn.

"Yeah butt-nugget, lay off him," said Drew. "Screw your card, go find another one. Maybe your rich bitch mom will buy you twenty packs. She should have an extra fifty cents after last night!" Tom and Robbie hurled themselves against the seats laughing.

Nathan climbed out of his seat. He took a step towards Drew, clenching and unclenching his fists.

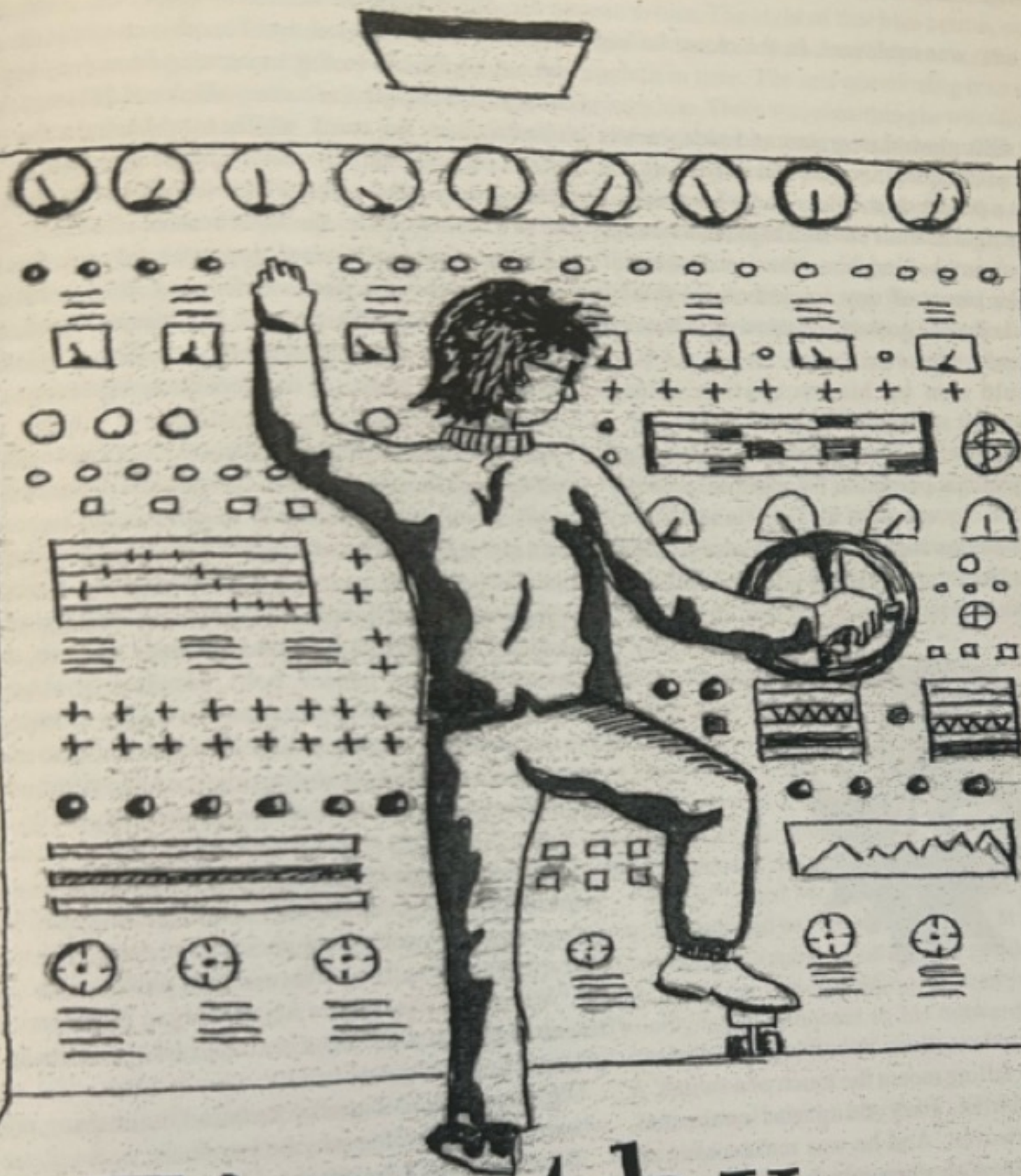
"Bring it pussy, I'll kick your sorry ass."

Nathan took another step forward and Drew stood up in the aisle.

Brad looked up at them, then looked again at Wendy Mulligan. Her head was cocked to the side as if to ask him, *Why don't you do something?* A little shiver passed through him; he wasn't sure whether it was fear or excitement.

Brad stood up in between them, swaying between the seats even though the bus was stationary. Sweat flowed down his face, and he opened and closed his mouth a couple of times before reaching for his shirt pocket. His eyes flicked to Wendy before meeting Nathan's. He pulled out the baseball card, still uncreased, and held it out before him. "I'm—I'm sorry. I guess I really wanted it or something. Here, take it back."

Nathan looked at him puzzled and took the card from his outstretched hand. He started to say something but just fell silent. He went back to his seat and slid the card carefully into its sleeve. Then he turned around in his seat again and gave Drew the finger. Drew pretended not to notice because at that point Sheila climbed back on the bus.



-13-

Timothy

by Joe Bellomy

This story begins in a closet; five by four by ten, narrow but with room to stand and room to sit and, if very tired, room to lay in the fetal position...the best position.

Protagonist? A little man called Timothy, three feet short of the height of a standard doorway; big footed, thin wristed, with bottle bottom glasses in plastic frames given to him

free of charge by the government while performing military duties in a relatively isolated communications site positioned on the hump of a land mass located somewhere in his memory.

Time? well, that is difficult. In a closet time does strange things. It expands and contracts, stretches like bubble gum,

his hand on her thigh. "My cousin works at the movie theater and we can get in for free." He scooted close against her. "We can go on bike rides all over town and I'm going to get my driver's license soon."

She recoiled from his touch and tried to pull away, but there was nowhere to go. "Excuse me, Drew, I need to get up. My stop is coming up soon." She tried to stand up but there wasn't any room and Drew grabbed her arm.

"Just skip it. I skipped mine." It was true. Drew had been so silent and Sheila so inattentive that she had driven right past his stop without noticing. Drew was normally one of those kids who charges to the front of the bus as it approaches his stop, slapping other kids' heads as he passes.

"I can't, my dad will get mad." She scrunched up against the window as much as she could and struggled just to keep his hand from going any further up her dress. "Look, just let me up and give me your phone number. I need to go now. I can call you later or something."

He leaned in close and tried to kiss her, but she turned her face towards the window. She felt his wet mouth against the side of her neck as she watched her house slide past. Brad and Nathan sat on their bikes at the end of her drive, watching the bus go by and pointing at her. "Let me go. We just missed my stop. I have to get off the bus or my dad will be mad and I'll get grounded. Let me go please."

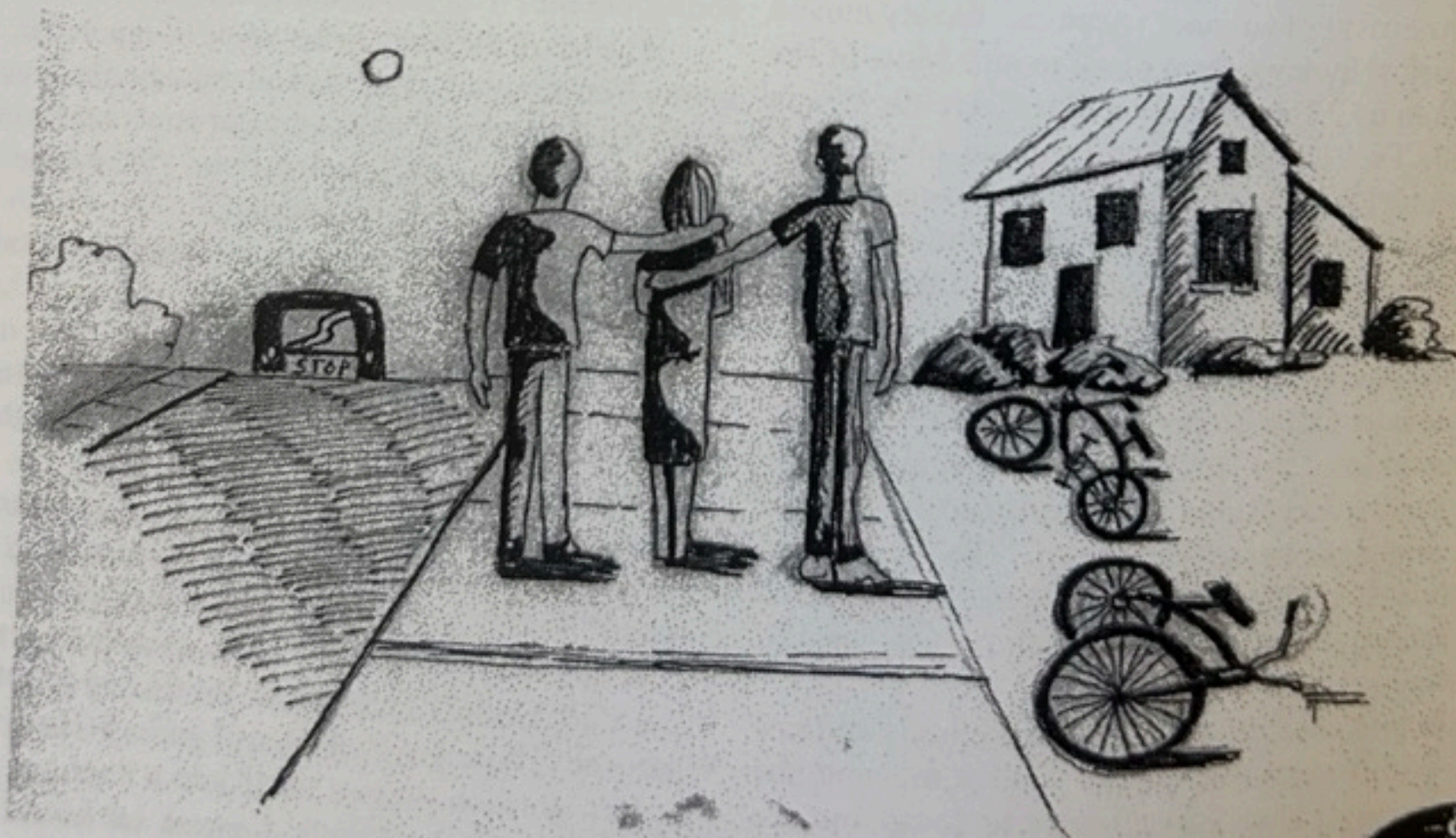
He stopped trying to kiss her for a second, but still held her arm and kept his hand against her sweaty thigh. "Are you crazy? You can't tell Sheila now. She's the meanest bitch of a bus driver there ever was. She'll drag us into the principal's office and call both of our parents and then we'll be in so much trouble. Don't worry about it." He leaned in close and pressed his lips against her cheek. She felt his wet tongue slide against her skin.

A few minutes later the bus pulled into the school parking lot. Sheila dropped the engine and leapt off the bus and shouted "Done!" She remained completely oblivious to the battle being fought behind the rows of seats at the back of the bus. Wendy told him to stop over and over again, and she fought to push him away from her seat, but he was twice her size.

He dragged her out into the floor and pulled her dress up, tearing the seams. She cried, but never managed to scream. If she had, someone might have come to see what was happening. He clenched his teeth and bit her shoulder as he grunted, leaving bruises and teeth marks. Wendy cried for her mother and Drew clamped his hand over her mouth to shut her up. There was blood, a lot of it. He left her there when he was done with her. She lay unconscious, and he climbed off of her and ran.

Brad and Nathan skidded their bikes to a halt in front of the bus. Drew was running across the parking lot, heading for the woods. They dropped their bikes and climbed on the bus. Nathan and Brad stopped when they saw the broken form of their friend lying half-naked on the dirty floor of the aisle, the sun casting its rays across Wendy's pale cheeks and bruised lips. Nathan stumbled off the bus and vomited on the pavement. He sweated and felt dizzy and scared.

Brad bit his lip and let the tears run down his cheeks. He crouched down and helped Wendy sit up. She was delirious and cried again. She whined about her torn dress and getting grounded, but Brad helped her to her feet. He knew what happened, but couldn't bear to think of it. They climbed off the bus together and Nathan took her other arm. Leaving their bikes behind them, the three hobbled to Wendy's house in silence.



"All right kids, no blood on the windows, that's good. Another bus is on the way, and a tow truck for this old girl. The replacement should be here in a few minutes, with air conditioning."

Everyone breathed a collective sigh of relief and a few of the younger kids cheered. Brad sat silent, exhaling in long, deep breaths. He glanced up at Nathan and a look passed between them for just a moment. It was one of those looks that sometimes passes between boys that none of them can ever speak of for fear of being called a pussy or a fag. It was a look of relief and of thanks, and also, a look of understanding. It was something that speaks volumes without words, maybe words can't even do it justice.

And Brad glowed inside. He knew Wendy watched the whole thing, and he was proud. He wanted to talk to her then, but he was still shaken. He had stolen the card after all. So he turned his attention back to the cornstalks and waited amidst the noise and confusion for the replacement bus to arrive.

Exactly three weeks later was the last day of school. Wendy climbed on the bus after school and looked around for Brad or Nathan. The three of them had become fast friends since the incident with Drew earlier that month. On the bus Drew always eyed the two boys with malice or leered at Wendy and so the three of them always stuck together. She saw neither boy today though, and remembered that they had ridden their bikes to school and would meet her at her bus stop after school.

Sheila paid no attention to the chaos erupting around her. She leaned over, yelling and laughing back and forth with the driver in the next parking spot. Kids hurled homework out the windows, standing up on the seats and cheering at the arrival of summer vacation. Wendy moved through the aisles, looking for a place to sit. Most of the seats were taken up. The only open seats were the two in back. She didn't see Drew at all and sat down, taking out a Jane Austen novel from her backpack. She opened it and tried to read, but the noise and excitement were distracting and she found herself thinking about Brad and Nathan, her first friends. She kept thinking of the way Brad looked at her, as if trying to communicate telepathically.

A minute later Drew dropped his ratty nylon bookbag in the seat across from her. He was sweating again and she crinkled her small freckled nose. She scrunched down in her seat and tried to make herself unnoticed. The bus lurched forward out of its parking spot and all the kids cheered again. A fresh wave of homework and old exams washed out of the windows.

Drew sat in silence. She looked at him closely and saw the bruises on his arms and cheeks. For a moment she thought that he must have gotten beaten up today, but she was sure she would have heard about it. The other kids would be talking about it right now if that were the case. He turned and met her eyes. She held his gaze without flinching,

but her palms were sweating and she felt uncomfortable in her seat. There was no malice in that gaze, no anger, nothing really.

"Did you get in a fight today?" she asked after a moment, surprised at herself that she was speaking to him.

Drew said nothing. He looked down at his bruised arms and shrugged. "My dad was still drunk this morning when I left for school."

They were silent after that. Drew sat staring out the window, occasionally turning to look at Wendy and to force out a smile. Wendy sat watching him and thinking about how his life must be. She felt sorry for him.

The bus moved through its route like a rolling party. Sheila was oblivious to the chaos surrounding her. She had her headphones on and sang along with Debbie Gibson as the kids climbed off the bus one after the other.

After awhile Wendy saw that Drew was watching her more closely. She began to feel uncomfortable under his stare and tried not to meet his eyes. She found herself wondering about Brad and Nathan again, wondering where they were and what they were doing. Were they thinking of her? She thought they might be waiting at her stop.

And then Drew was sitting next to her. The stink was almost overpowering, underneath the sweat smell was something much more subtle and horrible, like old socks that have laid at the bottom of the laundry basket for months. She watched out the window and pretended to ignore him.

"I think you're really cool, Wendy," he said after a moment. She felt his hot breath against her shoulder, barely covered by the strap of the sunflower spring dress she wore.

She turned and glared at him. "You think I'm cool?" She almost laughed in his face. But he looked sincere, and she saw the bruises again and felt sorry for him. "What's cool about me? I'm just a new kid, right?"

If he heard the irony in her voice he ignored it. "I don't know. You're smart. You read all those books. I can barely read. And everybody likes you and you've only been here a month." His gaze fell to the floor. "I've been here my whole life and everybody hates me."

"Maybe if you weren't so mean to everybody you'd make some friends."

He shrugged. "You're probably right. Hey, maybe we could be friends. We could hang out this summer and I'll show you around town and stuff. We could go to the movies and hang out and have lots of fun."

He looked excited. She felt happy for him and uneasy all at the same time. "I don't know. What about Brad and Nathan?"

A shadow passed over his eyes and then was gone. "Screw it, I don't care about the stupid baseball card. Whatever. Those guys are okay, I guess." He grinned.

Her stomach twisted itself into a knot and she broke into a cold sweat. "Well, I guess we could hang out sometime."

His eyes lit again with childlike excitement. "Yeah? It'll be great, you'll see. I know all the cool spots." He put

rolls like dough, boils like oatmeal and sometimes, granted only sometimes, stands as still as the memory of a beautiful face.

For Timothy time was irrelevant. In the closet he lost track of time.

On each wall dials glowed in greens and reds, meters popped outward, switches bent upward and downward, on and off. There was a peddle on the floor and a lever on the left and crank on the right near his elbow. There were buttons before him and buttons behind him, rows and rows of buttons; buttons like pieces of tiny colored candy that lit and buzzed and clicked when pushed and there were buttons which made no sound whatsoever.

Timothy could sum up his occupation in one word...balance. It was all a matter of balance.

There were moments when Timothy would contemplate the heavenly beauty of that particular balance: the position of his instruments, the movement of his body in relation to the demands of his environment. Lovely. It was a grand dance of balance and harmony, a symphony of equilibrium



composed of actions and reactions. A button kept a dial at a certain level. A meter falling meant the touch of a switch. A crank kept the switch lit. Everything was connected, coordinated and interwoven. And he was master of it all, knowing which button to push when, which switch to switch, when to crank and when to pedal, what was on and what was off. At times it seemed he himself was part of the system, not merely an operator performing a function, but part of the system itself, and it was at these times he felt the most comfortable, completely secure in his place and position, immovably content.

During one of these magical moments of union Timothy discovered the floor was electric. It was an accidental discovery made as the result of a simple question. More a feeling really. It was a slow, odd feeling of quiet uneasiness, when just for a moment something felt...well...off...

He paused in his movement and a meter reading began to fall. A choice presented itself, which should he respond to, the feeling or the meter, internal or external. A moment of

indecision gave rise to the decision itself. As he tried to define the feeling, the meter fell. Never before had it fallen so far. What were the numbers? Forget the numbers. The meter moved downward, and Timothy, caught in the crux of and unidentifiable feeling emanating from deep within his chest, *failed* to push the button which would return the dial, *failed* to turn the crank which would relight the button, *failed* to flip the switch which would reposition the crank, *failed* to press the pedal which would justify the switch, and as a consequence...the floor became electric.

The jolt sent him upward, approximately two feet higher than the height of a standard doorway. It immobilized his motor skills, stunned his senses, and completely eliminated the cause of his neglect (that feeling of offness) by inducing, quite suddenly, a state of timeless unconsciousness.

While in this nonlinear state Timothy's offness manifested itself through the appearance/experience of a series of sexual images which caused his body to generate an erection and emit a few sparse drops of seminal fluid into his undershorts. Luckily this process went undetected both by himself and his supervisors and was not recorded in formal report of his conduct. These images consisted of female acrobats, oriental contortionists, and fabrics, bolts, blankets of warm, wet, sticky flesh. Following this phase he began to experience the construction of mathematical abstractions, none of which he understood. It was during the construction of a six dimensional cube that Timothy was revived.

He found himself in his supervisor's closet, one of the most lavish, well lit closets in the entire complex. Timothy awoke muttering something about a net, a triple somersault, and a feat never before performed in a public arena.

"You know why you're here?" Began the supervisor, a round man with a flat nose and eyes like marbles in their glassy reflectiveness.

"I, uh, well I..." Timothy stuttered, not having realized where he was let alone why he was there.

"See this," his supervisor said, standing and pointing at a wall of buttons. They were all lit...all except one. One button, a blue one, fourth row down from the top, seventeenth from the left, an inch square, protruding a half an inch from the wall. Of all the buttons on that wall only one was not lit, and that one was Timothy's. His body became a single exposed nerve, vibrating from the top of his head to the pinched oval of his buttohole.

"I like to have my board lit," Continued the supervisor, "Lit. Balanced. Regulated. Do you understand that Tim? It's our motto here. Balance. Harmony. Unity. Continuity. You know the terms of your employment. They were agreed upon. But now, well, look here." He lifted a sheet of paper from his desk. "It says here you *failed* to note the dial, *failed* to push the button, *failed* to turn the crank, *failed* to flip the switch and *failed* to press the pedal. Timothy, I hate to say

"Lo Chi sent out the psychic signal. We need a juggler," Tony said. "The question is. Can you juggle?"

"He can juggle," Lo Chi lisped.

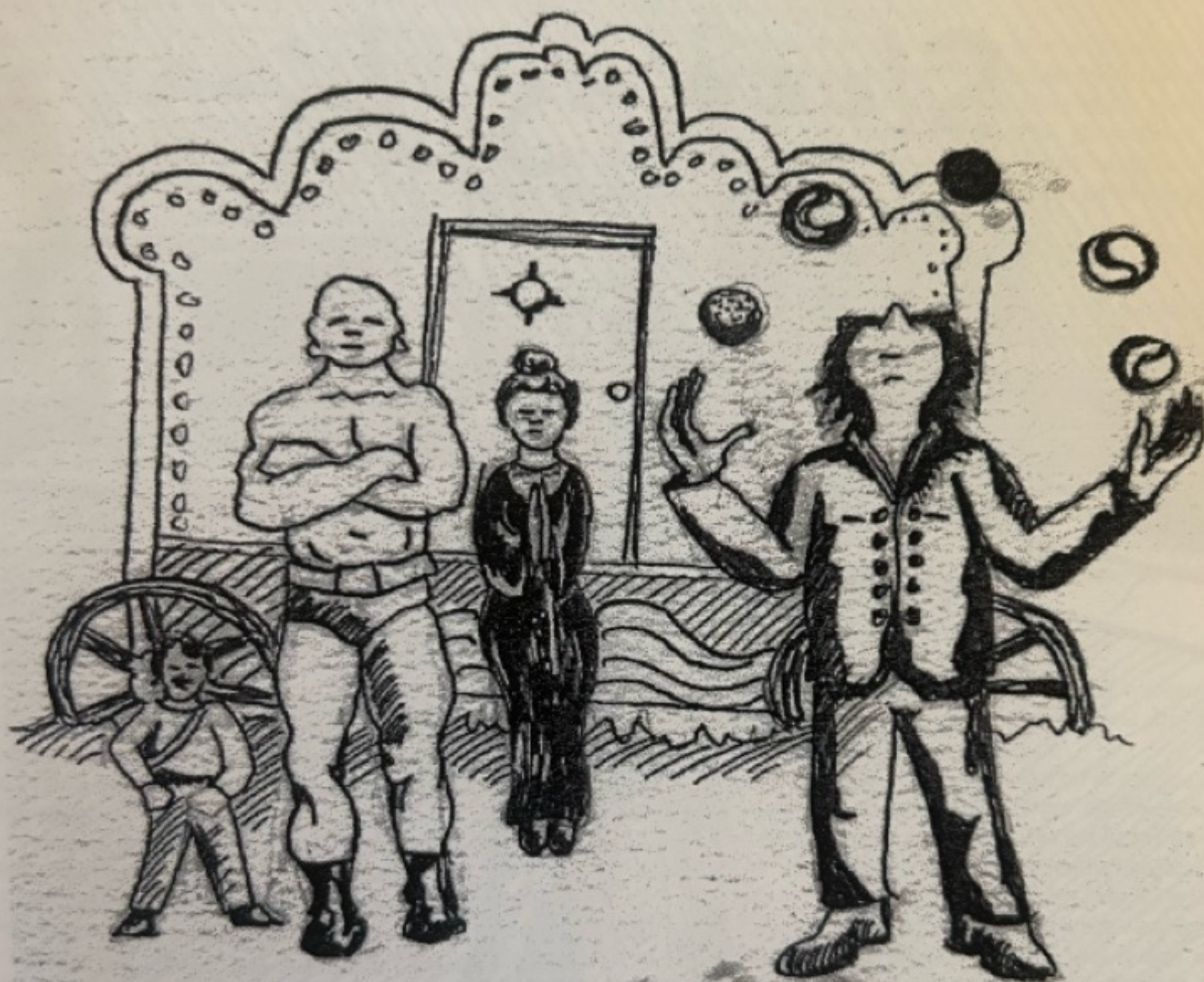
"Well...uh...my former occupation did involve the ability to coordinate various elements into one functioning, harmonious, movement." Timothy said.

"Juggling," said Tony. "He's the one, but I hope he quits talking like that."

Lo Chi took Timothy by the arm. "Come, the wagon is this way. There's much to learn out here in the *real* world."

This story ends in a circus wagon, amid hoops and rings and and balls and pins. Timothy found a much deeper harmony outside. And with the help of Lo Chi, forgot all about purpose.

joe bellomy



-17-



Timothy

hurried behind his desk and snatched up his intercom. "Yes sir, yes, yes, mm-hmm. Yes, I have him right here. Yes, sir."

Toby set the receiver down. Hatred smoldered in his eyes. He looked at Timothy. "That was the director of the complex," he said. "We've drawn his attention. I had hoped it would not come to this, had prayed this little situation could be remedied without moving to a higher level. But such is not the case."

Mr. Hobble shook his head.

"The director wishes to see you, Tim."

Sweat squeezed from Timothy's brow. His eyes moved sideways and up. He grimaced, smiled, frowned, and pouted simultaneously. He expressed a year of emotion. He would have begged for another chance had he a voice with which to speak. He would have groveled at their feet had he been capable of physical movement. But as it was he could do nothing except remain perfectly still and hope this was just and extension of his dreaming.

Mr. Toby and Mr. Hobble escorted him into the director's office.

The director gave no indication of recognizing their presence. He kept his eyes focused on a single yellow light bulb burning on his desk. One could tell he was highly agitated or maybe the furrowed brow, flared nostrils and deep frown were part his natural expression. His fingers flittered near his mouth and pinched his nose repeatedly.

-16- "This is him, huh?" He spoke, still focused intently on the light bulb. "I saw the flickers, yes, I saw them, *both* of them. Two flickers in one day, within two hours of one another! Contemptible. I thought my heart would stop. Oh, and it did stop on that second flicker. Thought you could get away with it I imagine. Thought you'd just let the lights go out. What a low, sneaky, contemptible little man you are. We've already got someone to replace you. That was easy. *You* are not needed here. I just wanted to see you for myself. Let you know that you didn't get away with it. No one gets away with inharmonious behavior. No one!

"Now, out with you. Throw him out! He'll never work in a complex again!"

With a kick in the butt, Timothy was booted out the front doors of the complex, out into the open air, out of a job and out of a way of life. Nothing was left to him. The complex had housed him, fed him, washed his feet and kept his fingernails clean. Now he was alone.

He turned and looked awhile at the tall buildings behind him. He gazed fearfully at the clear open sky, disoriented by the organic world.

He walked away. Hours passed.

How could this be? he thought. Years of faithful service ended in such a fury. He had only himself to blame. Hobble, Toby and the director were just doing their jobs, which was more than could be said of himself.

He walked and walked, away from the complex, his dear sweet home. He walked until his feet began to ache.

Then, he stopped and sat.

He was free to let his feelings go now. First he cried. That was needed, the release. He cried and cried. Then, he laughed. Then he cried some more. Finally, he slept.

The night washed over him. The stars lit of themselves. There were no buttons to push nor cranks to crank. The world revolved on it's own as a velvet haze of darkness slipped around him. He dreamt.

He dreamt people and places and wheels and color and things moving at odd angles. He dreamt death and pain and voices, laughing, whispering, singing. Touches he dreamt and kisses on his neck, his name floating on the breeze. He was a flag flickering in yellow light, and bodies marching and dancing. He fell and he flew. He sprouted wings from his back and talons from his feet, shed his glasses and his clothing and was a golden body floating in the night sky.

He rolled over and a blade of grass stung his cheek, jerking him awake.

Lasting cerebral distortions induced by too much stress and too little nourishment, he thought.

He sat up. It was still dark.

A rustle of leaves came from a clump of trees to his left.

"Who's there? Who's there?" Timothy whimpered.

"Come on!" a voice thundered, "He's over here."

A tall figure stepped out from the trees and into the starlit clearing where Timothy had slept. He was broad shouldered and dressed in close fitting black. Another figure stepped from behind him, very small, his head coming to just about the big man's knee. Then another figure emerged from the darkness. This last one Timothy gazed upon with his breath held. Her skin was pearl white, her hair blue black. Her face was a soft oriental oval. Her lips smiled without parting.

"Is it him?" The tall figure rumbled.

"Barney, don't be stupid. Who else could it be?" Squeaked the smallest. "No one wanders around outside the complex voluntarily. They're all too frightened, too comfortable."

"Who are you?" Timothy whispered.

"I'm Benard Barnicle," the tallest spoke. "This little guy is Tony and this charming lady is our own Lo Chi. We're a circus."

"Just the three of you?"

"We have a wagon," Tony declared indignantly. "You walked farther than most do after they've been expelled. Most just sit on the steps and fade away."

"I don't understand," Timothy said.

"Can you juggle?" asked Bernard.

"What?"

"We need a juggler. I'm a weight lifter, Tony here is an acrobat, and sweet Lo Chi is a fortune teller, psychic, and contortionist extraordinaire."

this, but we have never, I repeat, never, seen such a display of irresponsibility.

"I don't know what to say Mr. Hobbles," Timothy stuttered. "I don't know what happened. I had this feeling and I stopped to think about it and before I knew it..."

"No excuses Tim. Something must be done. Actions such as these cannot go unaccounted for. There are standards of behavior which must be maintained. A feeling you say? Stopped to think about it? Well Tim, I'm certain neither of these activities is mentioned in your job description."

It was at this precise moment that Timothy, taking a deep breath in an effort to relax, hiccupped.

Mr. Hobbles frowned. He liked positive response to his verbal counseling, constructive feedback. He was not quite sure how to categorize Timothy's reaction. Perhaps this response was due to a physiological imbalance caused by his experience of electric shock. On the other hand, perhaps it was this small employee's way of demonstrating his rebelliousness and disrespect for authority. Whichever, Mr. Hobbles didn't like it, didn't like it one bit. And where before he had planned to give Timothy only a verbal reprimand, now, he thought, perhaps he should consider consulting with his own supervisor as to what the best and most productive course of action would be.

Mr. Hobbles took a deep breath. His lower lip popped out. "As of this moment," he announced, "You are on ninety days probation. We'll be keeping a close eye on your conduct and can only hope such an error does not occur again."

Timothy twittered on his feet, his eyes glued to that blue button, fear twitching in his upper lip. He felt at any moment his morning meal would return and recreate itself in a colorful visual on Mr. Hobbles floor. He swallowed hard and managed to release a meek, "Thank you, sir."

Oh, how he had loved his work that morning, and every morning really. Now though, all had changed. The balance was upset, and this, this horrible asymmetric state could not be vanquished. His depression could not be measured. He had lost the ability to immerse himself in his work. He would have cried, but knowing as he did now that the floor was electric, refrained from producing the conductive liquid.

He re-entered his closet and quietly closed the door. His fingers trembled, his knees shook. Reluctantly he pressed the button which would begin his work. The humming began, but where it once signaled a deep esthetic response, it now evoked nothing but a thin film of perspiration.

Don't think of the floor, he thought. Don't think of probation, he thought. Don't think of not thinking, he thought.

The dial quivered. He flicked a switch, cranked a crank, pushed a button and pressed a pedal. The dial returned. And again through the sequence, the switch, the button, the crank, the pedal. A bit quicker this time. And again, and again, and soon he was working as well as ever, floating in

his function, reveling in union with the work he held so dearly. Then, as he reached the height of his ecstasy, a vision came to him. The sight of that blue button, extinguished due to his failure. A slow melancholy set in. The dial fell, but he caught it in time. The self questioning returned and washed through him. There was something he was missing, something to do with that button, something to do with his work, something to do with purpose. Purpose, he thought, and his mind drifted. Purpose, he thought, and the dial began to fall. Purpose, he thought and the floor became electric.

The last touch of the oriental contortionist drifted away and he heard them speaking. His name was mentioned and his awareness returned. He held his eyes closed. Perhaps they'll just wheel me away, he thought, send me to my cubical.

Mr. Hobbles was speaking. "It could be that first jolt killed a few brain cells."

"I don't think so." Timothy recognized the voice. I was Mr. Toby, Mr. Hobbles's supervisor.

"He's always performed well in the past," Hobbles said. (Hope sprang into Timothy's heart.)

"Past performance doesn't count for much when the lights are going out."

(Hoped died in Timothy's heart.)

"We may be able to rehabilitate him," Mr. Hobbles said.

(Yes, yes, thought Timothy. I'll be rehabilitated. I'll go to classes. I'll work very hard and I won't ever think of purpose again. I won't ever think of...) "Purpose," he muttered aloud.

"Ah-ha!" cried Mr. Toby at the word. How delighted he was. He radiated beams of superiority at having discovered this little man's subtle plotting. He nodded his head deeply with this new understanding. It was just as he thought. Timothy, quiet, innocent in his outward demeanor, was in fact, an insidious schemer.

"Now it's all clear," Mr. Toby said. "You've done all this with purpose."

"No, no." Timothy mumbled, "I didn't mean..."

"Mr. Hobbles," said Mr. Toby, "I think it is quite clear what must be done." He stooped, locked eyes with Timothy. "You, sir, are the lowest form of scoundrel. Look around here." Timothy looked around but saw only office furniture. Then he saw another board of lights. A wave of relief passed through him as he noted all the lights were lit.

Mr. Toby tottered to the panel, "I want you to see the results of your plotting."

"But they're all lit," Timothy protested.

"Lit yes, but see here? This button. I beg you, look closely at it. See how these three shimmer with their light. But see here, due to your unspeakable behavior, this last button, here. See? See? It's *dimmer* than the others."

Just then a buzzer sounded. Toby's eyes went wide. He



The Dreams of a Sleeping Lion

-18-

by
Ben Crites



My girlfriend Marie tells me what I need from life will come in some form or another. I'm leaning my head against the smudged fingerprints of a payphone at a Shell Station, my tie loosened and the top buttons of my blue Oxford undone, free from an interview at the Creative Testament Marketing Firm. Marie says the subconscious works like an autopilot, constantly navigating the soul. It's intuition, what Jung calls our sixth sense, she says. There's a quaver to her voice like she really believes these things. She clicks over to a call on the other line. I wait, wondering whether she's trying to cheer me up or test her comprehension of some book she's been reading. Two children with chocolate smeared smiles peek at me from the back of the van. A man wearing a fishing hat fails to stop the gas pump on \$20 and thumps the roof of his Suburban. Marie never comes back to me.

After a couple months of disheartening interviews and dismal projections in the classified ads, I'm apt to bide my time and wait for this subconscious to take over. So I'm back stocking groceries at Kroger, my fallback job.

It's Friday night and I've just finished stocking the cereal aisle. I break down cardboard boxes with my car keys. No box knives in the Kroger stockroom. The master thief conjured by my manager Phil has struck again. I imagine him in black pajamas, suctioned to the side our building with plunger heads, the box knife clamped between his teeth, soon to be added to a stash waiting in a secret fortress.

A radio DJ broadcasts live from a club downtown and I pine for all the activity I'm missing: beautiful women clinking sweaty drinks together, marooned by guys in black shirts and sleek shoes; all the gorgeous waitresses balancing trays of colored drinks and foggy beer bottles and dodging pool cues.

There are tiny paper cuts on my fingers below the nails. I suck on them and sigh. The sky grumbles – a dark front of clouds swirl in the beginnings of a vortex. I lean on the doorjamb to the back employee entrance and watch the sky's hurried movement.

I carry the flattened boxes to the dumpster. A fierce wind ravages the back lot, rolling pop cans and discarded beer bottles somewhere in the dark. I peer into the dumpster to determine how much space I have to work. Jutting out from beneath a cardboard box etched with a smiling Charmin baby are sandaled feet, hair arching like bridges over the gaps between the toes. I hurry inside and page Phil.

News travels fast among the inner circles of the Kroger team. You find out something – something juicy, I guess – and you feel this overwhelming propensity to unburden it and share in its gospel. So a group of us who walk this labyrinth of aisles on a Friday night, bound to rent payments and car leases, we pass the word along and seize the opportunity to do something outside of our job descriptions.

We stand by the dumpster debating whether or not to call the police. I wipe cardboard shavings off of my pant legs. Lisa narrates into her cell phone between drags off a menthol

cigarette. She has five roses on her nametag from spending most of her high school years scanning groceries at a cash register. No one can type in a produce code faster. Work is like prison in more ways than one. The more time you spend, the higher seniority. At Kroger, seniority is represented in felt roses on nametags. I haven't worn my nametag in months.

Marie digs her hands in her jean pockets and shivers. She has a powdering of flour on her Asics. She nuzzles against me like a cat. The wind blows her hair in gyrating swirls behind her head and I gaze at the shifting clouds shrouding the moon beyond that flapping flag of hair.

Phil trundles out, his tie wrapped up over his shoulder, his gelled hair coming unglued. He carries a clipboard with fluttering sheets of inventory. He bends down in front of the paneled opening, scrunches his nose and pushes his glasses back in study of the protruding feet. I watch a possum bump its way through the blowing trash. Lisa imitates a National Geographic host, her accent contrived British.

"Hmm. Yes," Phil says. He looks up at Lisa. "She call 911?"

"Rob Anthony broke up with Sara and now he doesn't have a date for the dance," Marie squeals, hurried like a valley girl.

We relive all the copious details of high school angst, confusion, all the complex facets of melodrama through a distorted squawk we have come to recognize as Gina, emanating from Lisa's cell phone. Not that I complain. It's good to be reminded of those feelings, to let the nostalgia warm me.

"Tell Gina you'll call her back," Phil says. This statement, delivered in the same direct manner has interrupted many beautiful daydreams.

"Is he dead?" Phil asks.

"I didn't check," I say.

"One could argue the lack of ambition and involvement in society has rendered him lifeless," Marie says and digs her chin into my shoulder.

Phil looks questionably at her and looks up at me, maybe wanting a nod of agreement. He hands me the clipboard, stretches his shirt up over his nose and sticks his head into the rusted dumpster. "Dear God," he gasps, "it smells like death." Phil's voice echoes inside, wanting to spill out into the windy night. At Phil's request Marie retrieves a long branch and hands it to him. She coils back around my arm, not that it was particularly cold. But Marie, like all women I've known, has heightened sensitivities toward temperatures. Phil's legs lift off the ground as he leans into the dumpster and prods into the covering of cardboard above the man's worn feet.

"He's in the dumpster now. I can see his crack. I think he's poking around with a stick," Lisa says to Gina.

"Hey! Get out of there, now. This isn't any place for you. Move on," Phil says. A big commotion follows; cardboard flops like sheets of aluminum, something smacks against the side of the dumpster.

woman who has both her kids jumbled in her cart with the groceries.

I clock in next to Lisa at the first checkout. She listlessly swipes brownie mix and cereal boxes with wild cartoon characters on them and the register clicks and beeps. Her phone is holstered to her hip and flashes with messages. She leers at me over her shoulder. "In a future age everyone will use the self checkout and I'll stand here reading the tabloids and chewing gum," she says. An older woman stands in front of Lisa wearing a plastic sheath over her rollers and she rustles through her purse in search of missing coupons. Two frazzled Johnny Rottens goof in line at the Ticket Master counter, their hair greasy and unkempt. I block their view of Lisa's butt and they crane their necks side to side in frustration.

"Wasn't that creepy last night?" Lisa says, tearing away a long roll of receipt and hands it to the lady in rollers.

"I felt for him, for the crazy life that pushed him into a dumpster."

She turns to me and smiles and I feel the warmth of it wriggle through my body.

"He was just lazy. A bum, really. He could be bagging groceries at least. I mean the cop . . .," she said.

"What about the cop?"

"Nothing."

"No, really?"

Her smile crumbles into a sad grin.

-22- "He's a frequent shopper. Spends most of his time at the bakery," she blows a bubble until it pops and leaves me in the wafted fruity scent of her hair when she spins around and places a plastic bar on the conveyer to separate groceries.

I peek over a rack of potato bread and buns. Those pensive eyes are fluttering and Marie smiles and laughs. The cop leans over a glass case of glazed donuts and cookies. He holds a Styrofoam cup of coffee in his hand and occasionally slaps the countertop enthusiastically with his other hand as though he was slapping a buddy's shoulder. Voices and codes gurgle over his wave radio. Sometimes he holds a hand up to halt her and turns the volume knob for an instant. He grabs her hand, dusty with flour, and gently strokes it with his thumb. Then he shakes his head and she laughs and licks her lips, keeping them moist as blueberry muffins.

I walk up to the counter. The cop composes a serious manner like I'm some urgency transmitting over the radio. He nods at me as you would any old acquaintance.

Marie nervously handles the introductions. The cop tries to fracture my hand when he shakes it. Bastard, I think and force a grim smile. We make weak attempts at small talk with Marie acting as interpreter. My heart shakes at the bars of its cage. The cop entwines his thumbs in his belt, a thumbprint of flour on his black pants. Phil finds me and instructs me to the stock room. I shy away.

"Gotta go," I say, "there are pyramids to construct." My voice cracks. Neither of them laughs.

Back in the stockroom I feel sick, maniacal, too, like I'm a bad actor jerked off stage and clawing my way back toward the gap of light between the curtains while stage technicians pull on my legs. The damn unsympathetic radio bursts out "Waterloo Sunset" as a sign that this treacherous life wants me thrown in a rowboat and pushed adrift the frigid waters towards Elba.

The thought of Marie and that cop bounces in my head like a rubber ball from a quarter machine.

I step into the break room to catch my breath. There's a local news broadcast on the television. A woman interviews a zookeeper. She tilts her head. "It's a very dangerous animal.

Call local authorities as soon as you see it," she said.

They show footage of a lion posing with a different zookeeper at a press conference. Then something aggravates the lion and it swats the zookeeper in the head with its massive paw. People scream. They cut to footage of the zookeeper's mangled face, as he is loaded into an ambulance.

"Just to recap, a lion has escaped from the Columbus Zoo and Aquarium," the reporter says. "Be on the lookout," she says.

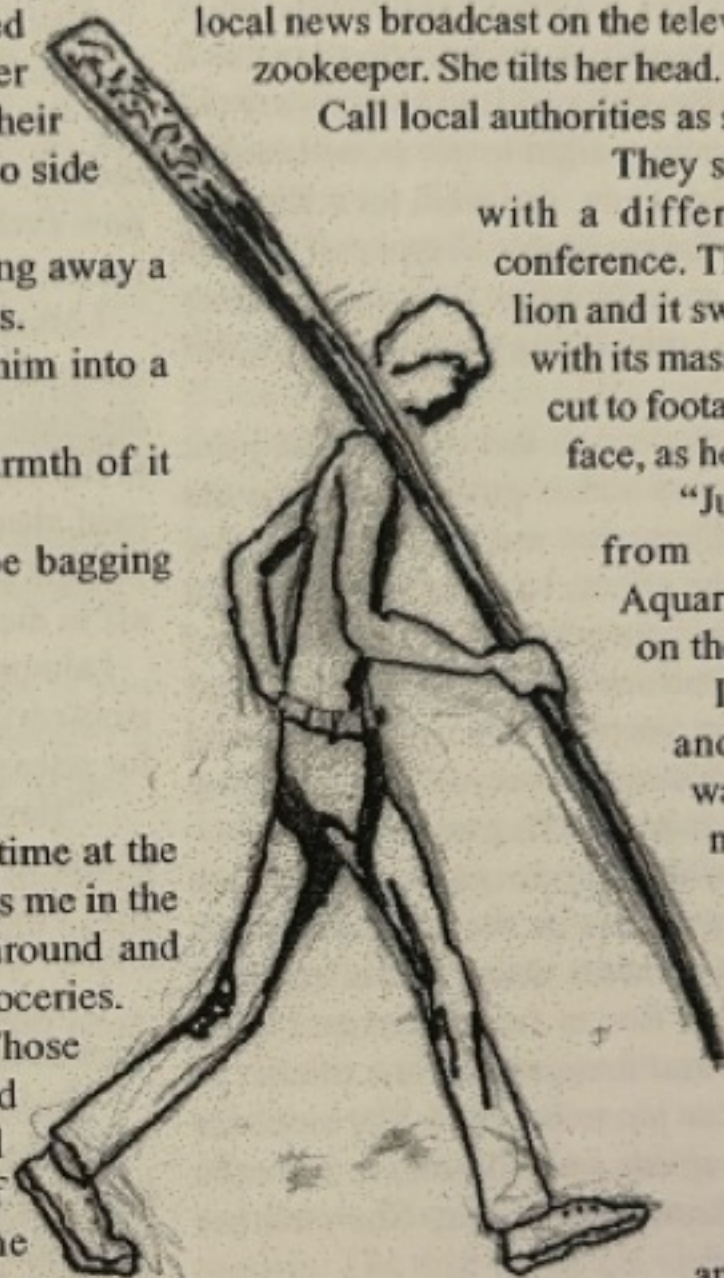
I step back into the stockroom and pace back and forth. Phil watches the change in me from mild employee to seething madman.

I pick up a box of tortillas and hold it for a while, letting the strain pull at my muscles as I stare off into Phil's eyes, his eyebrows arched like a children's drawing of birds, and that rubber ball bounces and bounces. I twitch. There's a

centipede on the floor stuck on its back, one hundred tiny legs kicking up in the air, and I drop the box on it. From its perspective it must've looked like the comet falling down towards the dinosaurs, getting bigger and bigger until it's everything.

I gather flattened boxes my diligent co-workers have piled by the back exit and I heft them outside with a stinging sensation of the edges cutting into my arms and wrist. I plan my retaliation, pacing in the alley, throwing boxes in the dumpster. But soon enough my courage shrinks. I fear what will become of myself when I piss off the F.O.P. I imagine them at their lodge, tracing my credit cards, cleaning their guns, idling in front of my apartment in the middle of the night.

I cry, and although it begins with heartache, my stomach sick and my bowels loosen. The embarrassment that I'm actually crying intensifies the flow of tears. I lean into the dumpster and puke. Soon it's just stringy bile; my gag reflex has nothing left to siphon, and I thirst for Seagram's V.O., to



disfigurement or scarring that necessitates a hood and a dumpster hideout. I wonder why Phil didn't find the situation extraordinary, why he left it to ring up an alcohol purchase.

Marie returns with a Swisher Cigar box and pulls out a sandwich bag of dope and some rolling papers. She separates the stems and seeds from a bud and twists the leaves into a cigarette, eyeing me as she licks and seals the paper. I sit up on her couch, feeling trepid from my scarred conscience, what I usually feel before getting high.

Maybe I'm medicating myself. Getting high seems to color in the lines of my life and makes the monotony a little more interesting. I envisioned the transition from college to "real life" being easy. But it isn't. Crestfallen, I lean back on my old summer job and come home every night to get stoned, watch taped episodes of Northern Exposure, and wish for a Rip Van Winkle sleep to dream away the inevitable Sisyphean routine of life. With luck, I'll save up enough money for a good recliner to come home and pass out in, completing the bourgeois's full circle.

Marie sits next to me on the couch and we pass the joint and listen to the music the wind makes gusting between the houses. The candle flames hypnotize me for I don't know how long. It's then I realize the effects have taken hold. For a while, I feel brilliant. We laugh about poor Bobby's unanswered pages and the fallacy of having no one of age working checkout. I theorize about the old bum, saying he's an experienced dumpster dweller, wisely choosing the recycling one. Marie laughs for a while. The wind snaps the flag out front.

Marie plays her old Casio on the pipe organ setting. I stare at her smooth eyelids and long lashes as she looks pensively down at the keys. The sustained notes make me sullen and I think about funerals and somber flower arrangements. I think about Lisa and her five roses and imagine her in a thicket of them picking as many as she can pin to her shirt. She looks for the perfect corsage. She picks up one and talks into it. She calls the rose Gina and wants to know its opinion. She cuts her finger and sucks on the wound.

Marie stops playing. We eat popcorn and drink a two-liter of Diet Coke under the soft light of the kitchen. We climb into her parents' bed so we can fall asleep to the History Channel. Some historian takes us to the icy tundra of Russia where Napoleon blundered. I go to spoon Marie but she's curled on the edge of the bed, so I close my eyes and listen to the TV. Some of us who are small dream big, the historian says.

The next afternoon I sing along to *Blonde on Blonde* in the shower. My face appears underneath the fog on the mirror. I decide against shaving and put on my dirty blue Kroger shirt, jeans and work boots. The sun blitzes in segments through the gaps of the blinds and dust motes waver like tiny magic carpets in the light. There's a note from Marie on the table, the writing rushed and erratic, without the hearts and smiley faces of her endearment.

I'm saddened by the clear skies, by the birds chasing each other from tree to tree, and hearing the jubilee of kids playing

their games in their yards. It's hard to rationalize the necessity of work to a restless soul on such a beautiful day. Deep inside I know accepting this will soon kill any passion I have left.

I drive past the Ohio State University campus. Students seize the sun like groundhogs freed from their frozen holes. They play hackey sack and smoke cigarettes on benches. Some march along the street in backpacks, all of them digging holes in the big ant farm, working diligently until the tunnels collapse.

A beautiful redheaded girl pulls up next to me at a traffic light and I want to be inside of her. I try playing a little eye-tag. Driving has changed since everyone has become disconnected. You use to be able to flirt on the road but now everyone is pre-occupied, staring forward and talking into cell phones.

I often wish that the giant Kroger sign looming off in the distance were a mirage. I'd get closer and the building would dissipate into a panorama of sand dunes. Like when driving in the daylight, sometimes you see silvery stretches in the road ahead which look like floods of water but the closer you get over every hump the mirrored water shifts further off in the distance.

I almost run over Bobby in the parking lot. He's collecting stray carts and stands stoically when I roar to a halt, begging for release. I park in a slant that takes up two spaces.

"Hey, Bob. You keep calling those 99s. Somebody's bound to hear you. Those college kids will wait, too. You won't believe how long they'll wait on cases of Beast or Natty," I say and mess up his hair. He backs out of reach.

"Lisa says you found a hobo. That's what you guys were doing at the dumpster last night. Fishing out a hobo."

"Yeah, well, they should give Lisa a rose for gabbing."

Bobby's lead cart has a busted wheel and he pushes on the train of them and it weaves side to side like a snake. There are white chalk lines where the stuck wheel scrapes against the blacktop. I dislodge the lead cart and heave it into an empty parking spot.

"What did he say? The hobo. When you woke him," Bobby says.

"Phil woke him. He didn't say anything, just seemed to want to keep away from Phil like the rest of us."

There are a bunch of blue shirts at a picnic table out front by the pop machines. They smoke cigarettes and yawn in the sun, stretching out their breaks as long as they can. One wild kid pinches a girl and then runs away giggling. A Salvation Army representative sits in a folding chair with a jar of coins and a stack of pink flyers heaped on a card table next to him.

I stand in front of the automatic doors and they won't open. I stare into the reflection in the glass and watch people stack paper sacks full of groceries in their trunks in the parking lot behind me and I marvel at the passing traffic far off, at life moving on without me this gorgeous afternoon. The doors won't open. I sneak in the exit, brushing past a

Phil thrusts out and falls back onto the asphalt. He holds a broken fragment of the stick. There are black lines of dirt on his shirt.

"You won't believe what just happened," Lisa says.

"Damn it, Lisa, call the police," Phil scowls. He pushes himself up onto his palms. Marie squeezes my arm so hard it throbs. I feel a needle-pricking sensation in my fingers.

Over the dumpster's dark opening a leg dangles, the worn pants have holes in them and I see scars on the knee that look like tiny leeches. His face hides in the shadow of his hooded sweatshirt. He wobbles backwards and catches the corner of the opening with his right hand and feebly struggles. I free myself from Marie and shake some feeling back into my hand. I step forward and grab under his armpits and lift him out. An operator's voice buzzes from Lisa's phone saying, "9-1-1, what's your emergency?" It repeats.

"What should I tell them? Phil, what should I say?" Lisa says. She sighs when Phil doesn't answer promptly.

Strangely, Phil pats the man down while I have a grip on him. He grabs Lisa's phone. "We've got a vagrant here causing a disturbance. We need him escorted."

The old man puts his arm around me like he's my drunken college buddy. He doesn't say a word and smells pungent of urine. His ankles are bruised and swollen.

"He's not disturbing anyone, Phil. The disturbance is you waking him," Marie says, reaching for the man's hood. He backs away and collapses against me. "What's your name?" she asks gingerly.

-20- The receiving door opens and casts an enormous, stretched silhouette of Bobby, a pimpled cashier. He cups his hands over his mouth. "Phil out there?"

Phil hands the phone back to Lisa. "What do you need, Bobby?"

"Man, I've been paging you for ten minutes. We've got a 99 up front."

Phil grabs his clipboard and walks toward the light of the stockroom. He stops halfway and turns to us, his features dark. "Tell them to come around back to the dumpster," he says, "no use making a scene out of this." His shadow gorges on the asphalt and a cool dark restores when he shuts the door.

Marie stands hugging herself, shivering. We wait until the far end of the alley illuminates and a cruiser pulls up to us, its headlights blinding. A young, mustached cop loads the man in the back of his cruiser. The old man looks like a monk with his head bent forward in supplication. The cop winks at Marie then slams his door shut with unusual aggression. I rap on his window and gesture him to roll it down. He smiles arrogantly.

"Where will you take him?" I ask.

"There's a shelter on Third. He'll be all right." He rolls up his window and sits there for a few minutes, having a conversation with his wave radio. He shoots a sardonic smile at Marie and drives away.

Marie stares at the oil stains where the cruiser had been. I wrap my arm around her to pull her to me, but for a second she doesn't give as though she's entranced by something in the

drops of oil. We walk back toward the receiving door, a metallic clink of a Zippo behind us, an excited exhalation.

"Gina, you won't believe this."

The remainder of my shift goes by quickly because I lose myself thinking and I'm unaware of the routine my body conducts. I think about the interview with Testament Marketing. I see the striped Armani knees of the Sales Manager rise and fall above his desk, like the humps of whales surfacing and submerging, as he crosses his legs. A man beside him, plump and pinkish like a newborn baby, sits with a tired expression, reminding me of Alfred Hitchcock. He has a beauty mark splotch of ketchup just above his lip. There are several full cups of coffee on the desk surface, covering a laminated Dilbert strip. Sunlight shoots intensely through a window behind them and I squint and shelter my eyes with my hand.

I think about the man in the dumpster, about what circumstances could lead him to trade a bed for a cardboard dumpster. I think about Jung and his belief in the "sixth sense" that Marie always talks about and I try guessing how he would explain this. Would Marie still argue the role of the subconscious? Do we secretly desire to make a mess of ourselves?

I can't find anything on the radio as I drive back to my apartment after work. I fumble with the dial. The synchronicity of commercial breaks among radio stations amazes me. It's possible there's a universal time to plug obnoxious car dealerships, carpet sales, and the riveting new cop drama; all the ubiquitous schemes of marketing I feign interest in during these job interviews, the soul wrenching business jargon-filled meetings to sell computers, my God! I turn the dial with hope of finding something.

Inside my apartment Howard Stern convinces a Playboy model to take her clothes off and sit on his lap. He guesses her cup size. My roommate sleeps in the recliner. His lower lip trembles. Maybe he's somewhere with topless playboy models. The dog-eared TV Guide next to him is splayed with six dead Bud Lights. Jackie Martling laughs derisively. I turn down the volume. The light on the answering machine isn't pulsing. No callbacks. No planes flying over the desert island.

I throw some clothes, toiletries, and a Calvino paperback into a duffel bag and drive to Marie's, hitting the dashboard and turning the radio dial endlessly. Along the streets trees bow in the whipping wind and I grasp the wheel to keep my Geo from spinning out of control.

Marie has showered and smells deliciously of fragrant soaps and lotions. She wears plaid pants and a long jersey. Her parents are in San Diego and I'm ready for her to jump me, but she grins and steps aside, closes the blinds on her front windows and turns off the lights. I trip over my duffel bag. She lights some lilac candles on her coffee table then disappears into the abyss of her darkened hallway.

I revel in the dancing flames and think about those sandaled feet, the hair on the toes and thick toenails. I wonder if his face is mangled, if there's something hideous he's hiding, some brutal

drink it until the reflex actuates again. I look down in wonder at my massive spattering and notice an opalescent stick onto which I've heaved. It has a pale glow of pearls. I pull it out, take my shirt off and clean it. It's colossal, like a shepherd's staff or a giant's hiking stick appearing to be made of ivory. On one end it's thick and smooth; it's ridged and twisted on the other. The smooth end has gold letters engraved in Arabic.

I throw my soiled shirt into the dumpster and walk around the side of the building to the parking lot. I carry the staff against my shoulder like it's a large musket. Around front the picnic table crowd mutters amongst themselves and then one of them whistles loudly, mocking my childish physique. I have to open my hatchback to fit the staff in my car, but I drive off, feeling a bit relaxed at the sight of the ominous luminescent Kroger sign fading away in my rearview mirror.

The homeless shelter on Third Avenue was a Y.M.C.A. until a fire consumed half of it some twenty-odd years ago and the remains were salvaged for the benefit of the disenfranchised. Cars bump by to aggressive bass rhythms. I hear the static pop of insects being electrocuted in a bug zapper across the street. The sticky stench of pot emanates from somewhere and I want to follow it, floating with my nose twitching at the imagined streaming plume of scent, like a cartoon. A black man with dreads and a ripped flannel shirt smokes a cigar by the entrance and looks at me quizzically, undoubtedly puzzled at the shirtless white boy and his long staff.

A corpulent woman with a greasy crow's nest of hair sitting at a folding table eyes me from top to bottom. She has a thermos of coffee, Grisham's latest courtroom drama pitched like a tent, and a stapled packet of papers in front of her. Not far behind her a man in a wheelchair stares at me as he chews on the end of pen.

"Where's your shirt?" she says.

"There's a man here. He was dropped off late last night by a cop. He wore a hooded sweatshirt and work pants ripped at the knees. He can't walk well. I think this is his walking stick."

"Honey, I didn't work last night. I need a name."

"Can I take a look?"

"Somebody's got to sign you in."

"I'll sign for him," the black man in the wheelchair rolls up to the table, takes the pen out of his mouth and clicks it. "You ain't gonna club nobody with that stick, now?" he says as he signs. He wears a beige army medic's shirt and stuck on it is one of those "Hello my name is" sticker nametags with "Marlo" scribbled in red ink. He leads me into a hallway behind the obese woman and her courtroom dreams. Stopping abruptly, he turns sideways to block me, taking the pen out of his mouth and clicking it repeatedly. "You gonna give me ten dollars now," he says.

"What? Why?"

"Cause I can get more out of ten dollars than you. Cause without me you and your stick would be hiking back to whatever God forsaken place you came from. Cause I ain't

letting you by unless you do," he said. I quietly mull it over. He clicks his pen.

"All right," I say, "I'll give you twenty, but you have to stick by me in case something happens."

I hand Marlo a twenty, one that has a pentagram branded on Hamilton's forehead and he folds it into his breast pocket opposite the nametag and then places the pen back in his mouth. He wheels up the hallway and stops by the doors at the end of it.

"They gonna stare at you. Don't stare at them. They hate being stared at," he says. He clicks his pen.

Beyond the doors is a large gymnasium that looks like a makeshift Army hospital with lines of cots. Long fluorescent light fixtures hang like sarcophagi from the rafters and illuminate the gym brightly, except for the far corner where two fixtures are burned out.

Many haggard faces shift toward us, some card games are interrupted, some of them gasp and laugh. Two basketball hoops are folded up toward the rafters. Boxes full of books and board games line one wall. Some have names of rooms written in marker on the cardboard flaps. There are tables with hot plates and giant soup pans, crock-pots, long foil pans, stacks of paper plates, bowls, and silverware lining another wall. The gym echoes with the struggling sounds of coughing and wheezing. A cot close to us has a bible lodged under one of the legs to level it out. In it, a grizzled man sleeps with his back towards us. Next to him a woman sits cross-legged on a cot rocking her crying baby. At the far perimeter of the cots, girls sing and jump rope, their hair braided tight against their scalp. It's hard not to stare.

I walk among them and try to smile warmly, but seeing them, watching the small routines of their lives confined in a gymnasium enhances the sadness I already feel. Marlo's wheels squeak behind me. Some of them seem so beaten that the sight of a shirtless man with a magnificent staff hiking among them doesn't draw a bit of interest. These people turn over in their cots or else open small slits in their eyes then sleepily close them. It smells of vegetable soup and burnt bread. We pass a man who scratches the back of his head with one arm. There's a flaccid sleeve where his other arm should be.

The old man in the hooded sweatshirt sits against the wall in the dark corner, his head drooped forward, his ankles wrapped in thick white medical tape. The staff glows in the dark of the busted light fixtures. Marlo clicks his pen behind me.

"Oh, you don't mean him," Marlo says. "Not him. Don't expect any 'thank you', he ain't got nothing to say. Do you?" Marlo rolls up to him. He clicks his pen to accentuate the impact of his words. "You ain't got shit to say."

The old man doesn't move. His features are dark, obscured by the hood and lack of light, and I realize the

the grand discovery—but man's home on the run, a cluster of stars closely orbiting the center of the galaxy. Since man left, he slowly developed the realization that he'd left something behind. Nobody really knew why they searched for Earth, and there was talk in some quarters on some occasions of halting the activity to pursue more productive research goals.

It was vital to check for brain damage—internal conflicts, memory gaps, minor subsystem psychoses—that might hinder the continuing function of the brain upon which hers was only a parasite. Dipping the limbs of her consciousness into the information flow from the master brain, Meroït was relieved to find a healthy central nervous system. The vitals check went on for interminable seconds while she verified every imaginable parameter of ship's function down to the subcellular level. It continued for seconds on end.

Finally, she turned the sensors on her own mind. It was here that she received a shock. She knew that reinitiating a personality from backup memories caused minor problems with memory—that was one of the many things Celtiberian taught her—but she hadn't expected damage to this extent. It was inexplicable. All the information she'd been given suggested that one could only expect slight memory loss, possibly a series of ticks. Nothing that couldn't be corrected by the psych rehab programs. But the damage she was seeing would require intensive chemical modifiers. It may even require physical intervention.

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In the middle of her own internal explorations, the ship relayed an alarm. It indicated minute but rising levels of a pathogen spreading out from near the damaged portion of the ship. Hoping her own glitches could wait, Meroït dispatched antigens to the site.

The ship's immune system was supposed to be self-regulating. It had a huge memory bank dedicated to storing data from previous infections. Unfortunately though, much memory had to be cannibalized for backup after the alien missiles detonated. The damage directly caused by radiation was serious, but it was all the attendant problems which really threatened the mission. Clotting had caused several small strokes in the ship's brain—killing pilots, and wiping out memory resources, it had been catastrophic, nearly fatal to the ship. Meroït was doing many things manually these days, working with incomplete information and trying to solve problems that specialized cortices of the brain would normally cope with. Most pilots wouldn't be flexible enough. For that, she had Celtiberian to thank. Most ships would have died. She imagined hundreds of the ships sent out to explore must be floating aimlessly through space, dead from relatively minor problems. Meroït felt ashamed that the human race could be so wasteful—and shame was one of the emotions that had become foreign to humanity long ago.

Quickly enough, the levels of pathogen dropped, and she resumed her own self-examination. Meroït was the last of this ship's pilots. Most of them had piloted along with

two or three others. They could keep each other free of glitches and act as backups in case one or another died from external damage to the ship's brain or became corrupted through repeated reinitiation from backup selves. Now, having lost the three pilots who saw her into the world—and a fourth, Celtiberian—Meroït was alone with her troubles.

The ship had passed through two spiral arms and a large portion of the galaxy's core over the last several thousand years. It had hosted some thirteen generations of pilots and had visited hundreds of thousands of planets, collecting samples at each. And it would have continued for another thousand years but for the loss of its personality seed—the subsystem that made new pilots—to the two alien projectiles. It was Meroït's responsibility, with the communication systems down, to see the ship home and to deliver the amazing news that Earth had been found. She'd be delivering more if it weren't for the damaged memory. She had to be certain she'd make it intact without letting little glitches foul her course or her progress.

The alarm went off again, and Meroït knew there must be an entrenched infection. She wondered where it had come from. Fighting the infection would be hastened by her personal investigation and treatment, one of Celtiberian's tricks. She wished she could access the memories lost when she had been restored. Though the pathogens were still at low levels, she decided to flush the system again in hopes that she could retard the progress of the infection enough to get a clear view when she entered the bloodstream.

Celtiberian had learned a technique to fool the ship into secreting, rather than scabs or leukocytes, a sort of humaniform vessel for carriage of a pilot into the blood. He was always tinkering with things. He had an insatiable lust for trying new things. It never made sense to her, but he seemed to think it should. Celtiberian had taken her into the bloodstream once for no reason at all. He'd shown her how to secrete a proxy body that could explore the inner workings of the ship's body. She didn't understand what she might gain by exploring the ship outside of the brain where she lived. Celtiberian was extremely odd. She worried for him, but she supposed that such anomalous personality traits were the inevitable result of spending so much time isolated with the ship's—humanity's—memory. The things he must have seen.

She created a proxy body by directing the ship to secrete a mass of muscle and sinew. The secreting organ was conveniently near the damaged area; apparently, the damage had allowed the infection to take hold.

She did a quick calculation to determine how long the ship would last at the current rate of pathogen production. Making antibodies was costly, and an already-injured ship didn't have the resources to keep up the fight. The only way to survive would be for Meroït to help the ship fight. Even then, it was a long way home. She was thankful for Celtiberian's idiosyncrasies.

THE MEMORY OF FLESH

by
Nathan McKnight

Being awoken from memory sleep is an experience that Meroit had never before encountered, though Celtiberian described it as something akin to having your brains passed through the intestinal tract of a large herbivore. She didn't know what that meant, but it didn't sound good. She also didn't know what had caused her restoration from backup memories. It must have been a traumatic event—the automatic process would only be initiated by a shock to the system—something that damaged the ship's brain, something that destroyed her own mind. There would be residual damage.

She immediately began the routine of checking ship's vitals—a task made somewhat more difficult and a great deal more frequent since the injury incurred several years ago during a close approach to a planet whose inhabitants had apparently mistaken the thin-shelled metallic egg of a spaceship for one of the vastly more threatening asteroids that packed their crowded solar nebula. The weapons they'd used left a broad radioactive halo marring the ship's aft. Its delicate innards had withered in the area like so many poorly-preserved biologic samples. Luckily, the blast had avoided the heart of the ship.

She dimly wondered whether the aliens were part of the biological spectrum that humans had left scattered about in their wake as they'd migrated the galaxy. But wondering was not part of the mission—the utility of knowledge was proportional only to the extent to which it served the mission: to trace Earth's location. Then again, what harm was there

in wondering now that Earth had been found? She'd gotten used to Celtiberian telling her extraneous information and she'd developed a certain affinity for the knowledge. She worried that she might have picked up a few too many of Celtiberian's idiosyncrasies.

The memories she had inherited from her backup self were approximately an hour old as compared to ship's time. She compared the ship's current heart rate to the rate she remembered. It seemed to be slowing a little, but was well within normal parameters. The heart was like any biologic heart, except from the inorganic polymer membrane that sheathed it and prevented the high-current nerve impulses from arcing across the muscle fibers. It pushed huge quantities of bloodlike fluid through the corridors and body cavities that made up the ship's mass. Unlike the fragile, gas-filled chambers used by so many of the galaxy's intelligences, this ship was one of flesh. This ship could withstand external pressure changes that would make foil of primitive, abiologic space vessels. Besides the hull, the whole of the ship was made of living tissue imbedded with plastic spicules and meshes and membranes. Its pilot was bodiless, thoughts roving the many cortices of the ship's brain, entirely contained in a living dream but constantly engaged with the body that supported it; a fully-equipped biologic cabriolet through the sparsely-populated chasms between star systems. The information stored in ship's brain was the only crew and the only cargo, and Meroit was the only one left to see its grand discovery home—not humanity's original home; that was

only reason I think of him as a man is because of the hair on his toes, which seems foolish to me now.

"What's he going to do with that?" Marlo says, pointing the gnawed end of his pen at the staff. He clicks it in agitation.

I kneel down and hold the staff across my open palms, extending it to the old man. He lifts his head but I can only see a shadowy silhouette of his features. The skin on his hands is dark and leathery but his palms are light and pale as if the staff has bled into his hands. He hugs it against his chest. I feel pain swelling in my knees cricked against the floor.

"See, man. See. Nothing to say. Not shit," Marlo says. He spins around and wheels off through the cots, his pen clamped between his teeth.

The old man reaches forward and presses his palm against my head like my mother used to when she checked for a fever. I want to be cradled to sleep. When I wake with my arm numb and throbbing under Marie, I'll whisper this dream into her ear in all its dramatics.

Children jump rope and I listen as it slaps against the wooden floor, the kids rhyming, their shoes squeaking like basketball players. The rhythm of the jump rope slows and synchronizes with my heartbeat, and the rhymes become lethargic and disoriented like a tape player low on batteries. I close my eyes.

A lion roars. The old man pulls his hand away and I open my eyes. The homeless are sitting upright on their cots looking around, spooked like dogs. Children cry, the jump ropes dangling from their hands. The lion roars again and it's in the hallway. Its shoulders swaying up and down as it creeps toward the gymnasium. Two men slam the doors closed. They frantically search for something to secure the doors with. People scream and scatter in our direction, one of them pushing Marlo like they're running with a wheelbarrow. They huddle in the dark corner.

The old man stands and towers over me. He hobbles through the mass of cots, leaning against the staff. The two men rip it from his grip, pushing him aside and secure the doors with it.

I run across the gymnasium, hurdling overturned cots, and I help the man up off the floor. He staggers and leans against me as a crutch. The two men step back from the doors.

"It looks pissed," one of them says.

Through tiny windows in the doors I see the lion on its haunches. It leaps against the doors and I fall backward, the hard floor jolts my tailbone and the crowd screams behind us. The doors separate slightly, bending until they catch against the staff. I jump up and look through the window. The lion roars and walks back with its head low. Its muscles look like they have been sculpted from stone.

The old man stands up next to me and looks through the window.

As the lion prepares for another lunge, two men in green suits appear at the end of the hallway with rifles. They shoot two tranquilizer darts in the lion's hindquarters. It yelps, snaps around, and runs at them. They duck out of the hallway and the lion disappears after them.

The old man shakes the doors.

"Are you kidding me?" a man beside us says.

I pull the staff out of the doors and pull the old man into the hallway with me.

"What are you doing, kid?" one of the men asks.

I give the old man his staff and he walks with me down the hallway where the lion is roaring and two men are screaming. "Shoot it again, damnit!"

The lion staggers. It turns towards us and roars with its eyes half-closed. Hunkered again in a crouch, the lion can't muster the strength to attack and falls into a heap at our feet.

I watch the old man bend down to the lion and stroke its mane. He pushes the lion's eyelids open, revealing a large white eyeball that's rolled back in its head. He rubs his throat, then opens the doors and hobbles out into the windy night.

Part of me wishes that the lion mauled me, that I would have this disgusting gash seeping through the gauze while I lay in a hospital bed, Marie weeping above me and lightly touching my wound. I would show her where it hurts.

So here I am, this shirtless, impish boy who's afraid to summon up his strength and be a man, standing over the hulk of a lion, who may very well be dreaming of the impala he dragged into the thicket some long gone forgotten night. I want to forget everything.

But here I am, just another boy without a date for this spinning dance of the seasons. Day twirls into night back into day.

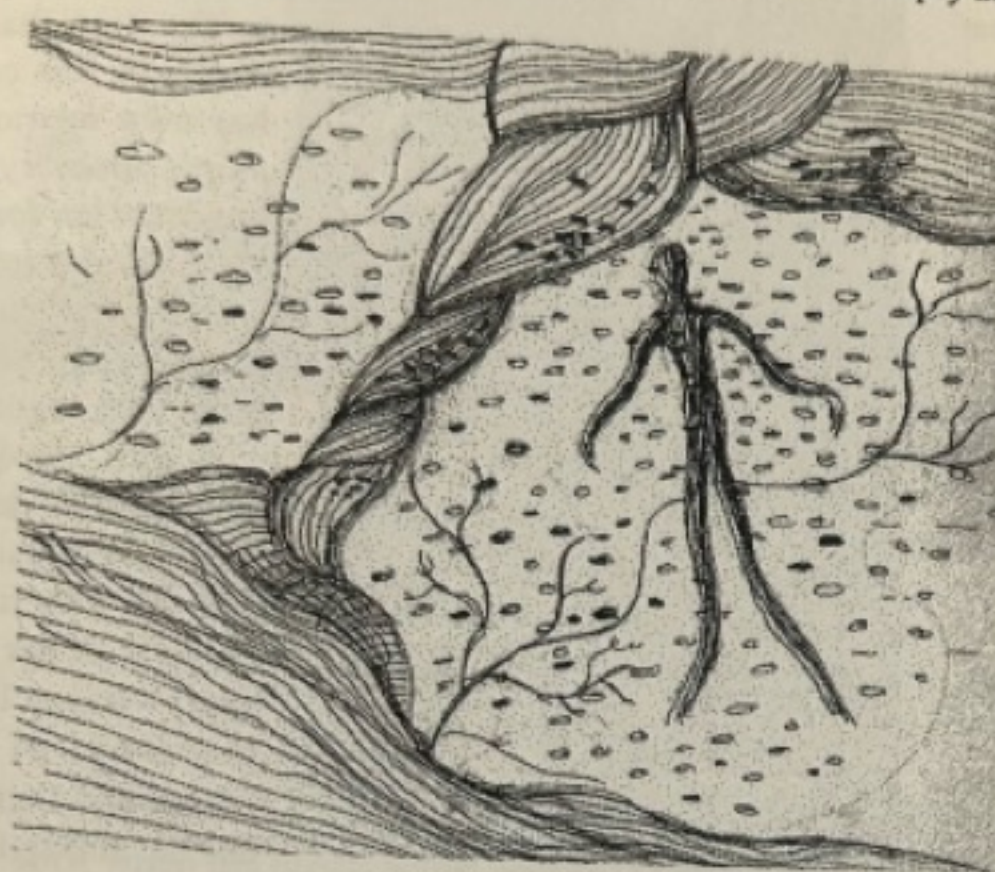
I could call Marie and sort out this cop situation. But what would I say that would be heard? I could go home and flip on the History Channel, maybe catch more about Napoleon, and this time I'd listen intently, while I lick the salt and scattered kernels of the empty popcorn bowl. I'd listen to find out what went wrong.

I could return the sting by walking into the bakery with my fists clenched, my eyes wild and tearful, and make a beast of myself until the authorities sedate me and I'm only left with dreams of how everything was and could have been.

But I won't. I know my limitations. I'll be stoic. I'll move on like the old man, in a sense. I'll take whatever is given to me and make do with it, quietly, and perhaps, that's the loudest noise I can make.



He'd been born as a glitch. When the first of the missiles had hit, he was generated accidentally as an emergency backup because the memory cortex temporarily lost contact with the rest of the ship. It had automatically created Celtiberian to think through a strategy for reconnecting. He did his job for 77 milliseconds before the second missile hit, delivering a jolt that realigned the broken neurons and re-established the connection. Meroit had been the one designated to slip through the connection to inspect the memory banks. She met the stranger there, and conveyed him back to the main cortex to confer with the other pilots.



Manchu, Jurchen, and Ol Cemert fired blasts of coded thought back and forth through the ship, trying to decide what Celtiberian was to do. The three old pilots discussed the new pilot situation, all the while struggling to poultice the destruction which had created him. A fifth pilot was superfluous and human history had shown well what happened with idle hands. Eventually, it was decided that Celtiberian would survey the memory damage. He was to check each synapse and cell. Though it was an unusually simple job for an intelligent pilot to do—simple automatic subminds usually handled such menial tasks—it was very time-consuming. The memory was enormous. Tracking down the origin of humanity meant collecting and analyzing samples of life forms and artifacts, comparing records of geomorphology, history...virtually all of collective human knowledge. Celtiberian had to make sure all of that information was accessible and he went about his job with exceptional vigor.

Meroit had to perform her job now to ensure safe passage for the result of Celtiberian's and the others' work. Her mind slipped carefully out of her subcompartment of the ship's brain, sliding through the peripheral nervous system and into the temporary body that had been secreted and awaited the animation brought by conscious thought.

* * *

The secretion organ dissociated itself from the proxy body and Meroit crawled along the vessel walls against the current of blood. The body had scaly, plasticene spicules that acted as manipulators and allowed her to grasp the tough muscle of the artery. She spread her limbs and fanned-out her digits, smelling, feeling, tasting the contents of the blood with exposed nerves. Surprisingly, the ship's own antibodies began to attach themselves to her hands and arms.

She ignored the problem and followed the feel-taste-scent of the pathogens, but as she crawled farther, the pathogens dwindled, then almost disappeared, save for those attached to her proxy. Buffeted by the current, she went about her job, but to no avail. There seemed to be no locus for the infection. The pathogens were simply all around. After an excruciating moment of searching, she gave up and hurried back downstream to the secretion node to attempt diagnostics with the help of the ship's brain.

She found it there. The node itself was infected. Antigens continued attaching themselves to Meroit. She hurried her examination, noting unusual lacerations that didn't seem a likely result of an infection.

She needed to be quick since the body she inhabited was very delicate—a mere hint of human form, little more than a bundle of nerves sketching the trace of a tiny-brained body. She could be damaged easily. If she remained in the bloodstream for too long, the antigens could degrade her spinal cord and the proxy body would die. Then, she'd have

to be reinitiated again, losing more of her own memories, more of the memories of Celtiberian. She feared that the ship might also die. Or, in making it home, she would suffer so much brain damage that she wouldn't remember any of the experiences they'd shared. She wondered what had caused her to go through the reinitiation before. Something to do with the infection?

The infection was deeply entrenched, eating away portions of the secretion organ. This was a serious problem, and probably the reason she was being sieged by antigens—her own proxy body had been secreted by the infected organ! Such a situation was intolerable, and she struggled to clean the invagination that housed the pathogens. Slowly at first, Meroit pulled loose cheeselike globules of bacteria, but the infection was deeper than she could reach. She dug with her clawlike spicules.

Meroit felt a trembling in her proxy muscles. She would have to clean the site thoroughly. Otherwise, she wouldn't be able to secrete any more proxy bodies to examine future infections or injuries or other problems that could threaten the life of the ship and destroy the information contained therein.

The antibodies attacked the infection as well as the proxy, not differentiating the one from the other as she tried to help them fight.

Soon, she could not work efficiently, and she began lashing out at the infection with sinewy limbs and sharp spicules. She panicked, and in her panic, she inflicted minor lacerations on the wall of the organ.

Soon, she started to break little pieces from the vessel walls, started breaking into little pieces herself. Then, she stopped. She

was doing damage to the ship. And the damage was identical to the lacerations she'd noticed earlier. Meroït had trouble connecting thoughts in this temporary body as its nervous system deteriorated under the siege by the ship's immune defenses, but a thought was there. What had caused the older lacerations?

She darted for the nervous interface on the secretion organ. She had to get back into ship's brain. She couldn't let these memories be lost when she was reinitiated. She couldn't let herself go through memory sleep again. She'd done this before, she thought. She'd been here and fought this fight. How many times? The memory damage was extensive. She must be stuck in a cycle of rebirth, fighting, rebirth. How long had this infection been here? How many times had she fought it?

For the first time, she considered her own survival apart from the survival of the ship, the completion of the mission. Her proxy body was coming apart, and she flailed, trying to connect to the interface. If she didn't, she would repeat this over and over, degrading further each time. Then, she would be dead and so would the memories of Manchu, Jurchen, Ol Cemet...and Celtiberian. She felt she had to protect those memories, though she did not know why.

The nerves were badly damaged, but she could still access the ship's brain. She calculated that the ship would succumb to infection long before it reached the home systems. If she stayed out here to fight, the ship might make it. But she would not. It was selfish even to consider her own survival when the mission was at stake, and so close to completion. She was charged with bringing the news of Earth back to humanity. She was not charged with bringing back her own memories. There was no need for the survival of her affinity...her love—for Celtiberian. She had to communicate the location of Earth so that humanity could find what it had lost.

She accessed the ship's memory. The vast landscape of human history which Celtiberian had found so fascinating had been gone since the stroke, the worst in a series that continued to erase little patches of ship's memory even now, since he and the other pilots had been killed, since Meroït had been left alone. Now, what little

memory was left was being used to store the information that would allow humanity to find its way back to their original home. She erased that information.

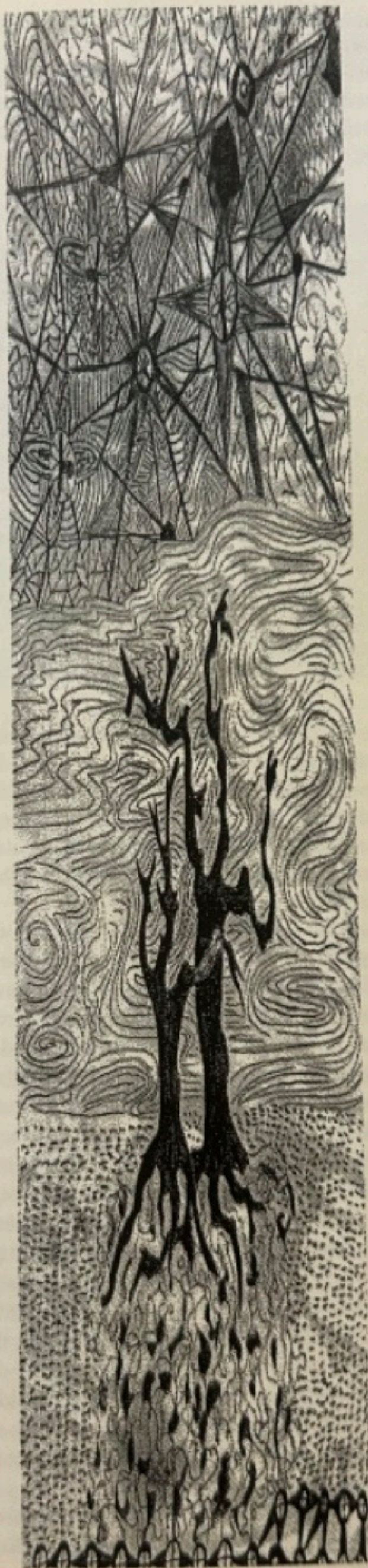
She erased the location of Earth, though it would be thousands of years before humanity sent another ship back to the area that this one had already explored. She erased it, and transferred her own memories to the pittance of ship's memory left. Humanity would condemn her for the selfish decision, and she was ashamed of herself. She felt weak, and not because of the pathogens—though they were attacking her proxy body with vigor.

She had been infected by Celtiberian's damned idiosyncrasies, his damned curiosity, his damned self-love, and she'd sacrificed the mission for the survival of her own memories. She was angry—angry, like no human had been for thousands of generations—angry at herself and angry at Celtiberian for giving her the ability to feel anger.

She unleashed the anger on the infection, digging at it, attacking it even as the antibodies attacked her. She ripped at the infection, ignoring her own disintegrating proxy body, ignoring the weakening of her arms, ignoring the little pieces of wrenched tissue as the antibodies digested her. Soon, she was flailing at nothing but the flowing blood. Soon, she could not hold onto the wall, soon her limbs began to fall apart, and she broke up into fragments, carried off by the blood to be reabsorbed by the ship's liver. She lost consciousness and died once more in the blood stream.

* * *

Memory sleep was a discomfort Meroït had never before experienced; it was like having your brains passed through the intestinal tract of a large herbivore. She immediately began scanning ship's systems, saving her own memories for last.



will be crawling his limp body back onto the slope again, on the lookout for any rash shortcut, I hoped.

The light outside, I insisted, would do him good.

He shielded his eyes with his hands, cursing his lost sunglasses as though they would make everything copasetic. He bent the visor in every direction then, out of futility, flipped it against the ceiling and covered his eyes. I scanned the trees and mailboxes and street signs as they flashed away from us.

"I can see hot red light through the skin and bone of my hands," Wallbacher said. "Why haven't you tinted these damn windows?"

I pushed my Neil Young *After the Goldrush* cassette in the tape deck, knowing that good music can alleviate any blight in perspective. This one had smoothed over several ruffled feathers before. Some of the tape was twisted like a tongue from its excessive wound licking.

I pulled into Huntington Bank, figuring the best thing to do would be going about my business.

Wallbacher moaned like a sick dog next to me, hanging his star bedazzled head out the window. It was Saturday and I was feeling the brief security of still having yesterday's paycheck in my possession. I scribbled my account number on the back of an old envelope and signed it, then crammed my paycheck, the envelope, and my driver's license into the capsule and launched it to a dark haired girl who had her head bent over some deposit slips.

She looked up and reached for the capsule. Wallbacher moaned next to me. "She's beautiful," he said. Indeed, she was, an iridescent sleek flag of black hair, a sharp, aquiline nose, and her smile as seducing as hot breath on your ear lobes.

She spoke into a microphone, which sounded a muffled squawk.

"Hello, how . . ." Wallbacher leaned over me and clasped his sweaty hand over my mouth. His other hand was anchored way too far up my thigh.

"Good morning," he said. "We have another transaction if you'd please send back the capsule," he said.

My voice was muffled under his hand until I chopped at his sore ribs and he withdrew it.

"What are you talking about, another transaction?" I said.

"No time," Wallbacher said rummaging through my glove compartment. After spilling most of its contents on the floor he produced the manual to my 96 Ford Escort and ripped two pages out of it.

"Ah, come on, what are you doing?"

He picked up a pen off the floor and scribbled a long poem between illustrations of children's safety. One of them enacted what would happen if you placed a child in a car seat backwards in the front passenger side. He shifted his tongue from side to side.

"Grab the capsule," he said.

"What? Come on."

"Grab it!"

I reached for the capsule and smiled at the bank teller who no longer smiled back. Wallbacher stuffed the pages into the capsule and handed it to me.

"What's this about?"

"Launch it, damnit!"

I watched with gloom as the capsule sank slowly into the chamber and then a rush of air sucked it through the tubes to our impatient teller. She snatched it and seemed to mull it over a while and then she vanished from the



window.

"Ahh, man. Where'd she go? Where's my money?"

Wallbacher opened and closed his hand next to me and shook some feeling back into it. He looked meditatively off into the parking lot of Kroger where a kid was collecting all the scattered carts in the wind, his shirt convulsing like there was some animal thrashing around inside it.

The teller returned with a man in a full pin striped suit who stood next to her and folded his arms. His complexion was dark, suggestive of Italian heritage, and he scowled at us. She turned back to him and held her palms out, shrugging at something it seemed. The man squatted down to the microphone.

"Gentlemen, this is a business establishment and we'd appreciate that you conduct your behavior accordingly," he said. The man pinched the knot on his tie and tightened it to his throat.

There was the sound of rushed air and out popped the capsule. I scowled at Wallbacher. It held only the green deposit receipt and my driver's license. I feared that every transaction I made from there on out would elicit the same scowl, no matter which teller attended me. Now there would be a note on the computer that would pop up whenever

"Nah. You see, sometimes you need physical pain to forget about emotional pain," Wallbacher said, grimacing. He squinted and rubbed his ribs.

"Jung say that?"

"I don't know. Probably."

And so Wallbacher propped himself on a couch, his feet smashing the Mike Sells, ready to expound on the difficulties of finding a suitable companion. Men, our internal oceans should house all the bobbing bottles encasing the things that don't float, but should sink into the cold abyss where their soggy messages are smudged unreadable.

But Wallbacher was bent on catharsis. He would hand me a notepad and I'd busy myself with something else, maybe scribble down my dream I had the previous night, or I'd postulate on the chances of the Buffalo Bills going ten and five this year. You can only take apart a broken machine and randomly press wires together so many times to see if they spark. Shrinks must surely see this as an axiom of their profession.

Wallbacher squinted his eyes, struggling to open them as if he'd been belted hard on the head and had developed an irreparable twitch. The Sauvignon pulled his brain from his skull like it was a wad of gum stuck in his hair. Poor sap. He was Cupid's pincushion, walking around like an old drunken extra from a silent Western flick, arrows jutting out him like porcupine quills.

He began a great roaring monologue on his date the previous evening with a gorgeous medical student named Mya. He spoke with a lit cigarette stuck to his lip, glued with his sparse saliva, not that he was a smoker. He didn't drag off the thing, but he had an image of the great defeated French lover to carry out, wearing black Levi's and a charcoal tee shirt like some hack art student. His voice became soft and tremulous over the difficult parts where he claimed to have seen a glint of promise in Mya's eyes while she forked an oozing chunk of chicken cacciatore. It was the one moment they shared suggesting possibility, he said.

He dredged retrospectively in bewilderment, shaking his head. He confessed fear of not finding a true woman meeting his criteria—a mender of wounds, a scrambler of eggs, a warmer of beds—a true simpatico to nurture the wounded landscape of his soul.

In that moment, Wallbacher said, a strand of her strawberry blonde hair fell down into the cream sauce. He brushed it back behind her ear and smiled warmly at her. He was overpowered by the glint, a shimmering distant fire across the hazel terra of her eyes, and Mya's face reddened, what Wallbacher said he initially saw as blushing, but as it turned out a chunk of chicken and peas had lodged in Mya's throat.

"Is she all right? What did you do?" I asked.

"Well I jumped up to give her the damn Heimlich, but she'd fallen backward onto the table behind her, her legs kicking up in the air like she was drowning and a couple of guys grabbed her and began pumping away at her."

I imagined the very details of this scene. Wallbacher watching as these burly guys, college sport hats backwards, wearing Abercrombie vests, passed his date around and each took a turn at her from behind.

"They saved her life," Wallbacher said sorrowfully.

"Well, shit, that's good to hear," I said.

"Oh yes, quite good." He stood up and wet a rag in the sink and hunkered over the coffee table to clean the spilt droplets of bloody wine.

"What's the damned problem then?"

Wallbacher separated his thumb and forefinger an inch. "I was this close to making a genuine connection."

Everything had gone perfect up until that point, he said. He had acted as a true gentlemen, holding doors, helping her into his Suburban, listening intently to her conversation, full with puzzling medical terms, and thoughtfully replying to show he was interested in what she said.

Wallbacher said everything was leading up to that moment, and once shared, there would have been insatiable desires to be around each other, ever long moments waiting for phone calls, at least three months of incredible kindness and sweet sincerity.

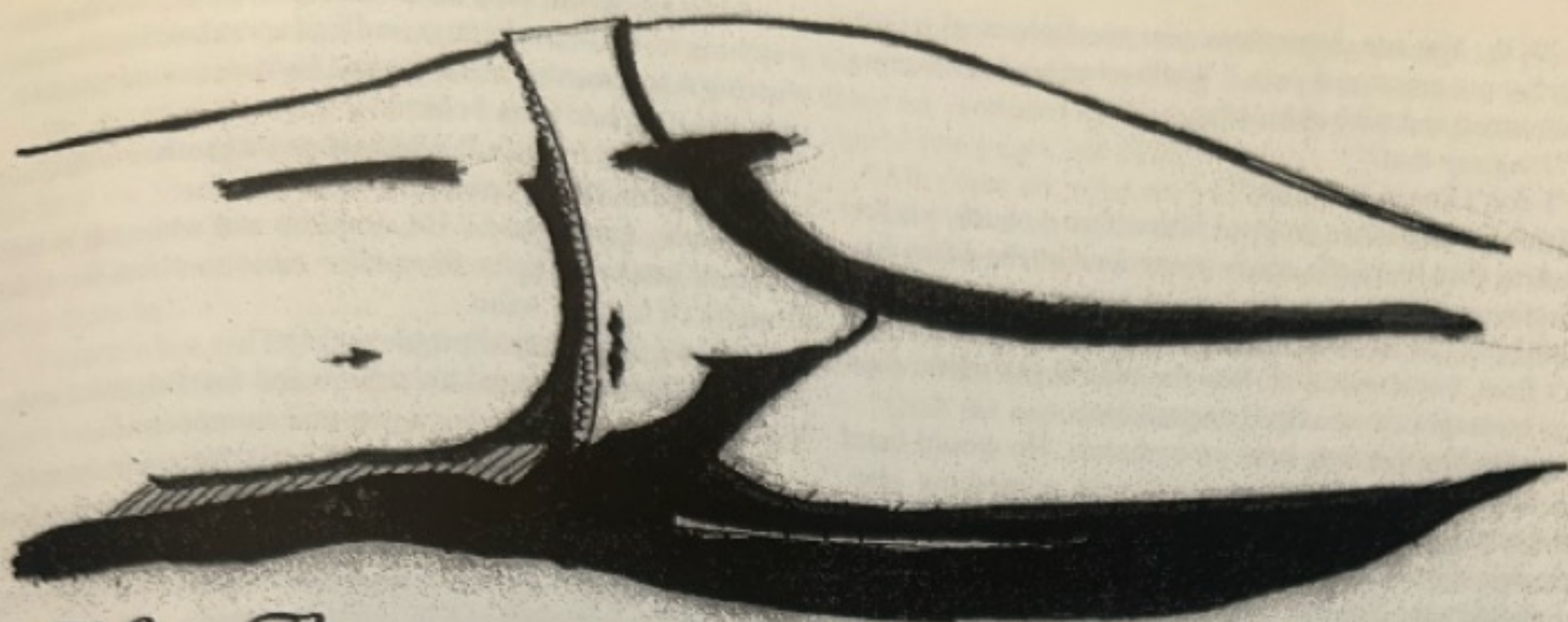
"That was the last time she ever looked at me," he said.

"She choked," I said.

"Yes, she choked. Then insisted on buying the guys a drink and they encircled her at the table. She smiled at them, and every time I opened my mouth to speak, somebody stole the opportunity, talking inanely about some party, lodging peas in my throat, dammit. Eventually the jackals dragged her off to a kegger," Wallbacher said softly, hushed by the painful remembrance. "They stuck me with the tab, all \$85 of it, and walked over me and out into the night. The beautiful Mya was taken into the hills by a bunch of savages. I retreated home with the Cabernet Sauvignon, and well, you know the rest."

I hoped taking Wallbacher out into public would be like dragging Proust out of seclusion and sicking him on every curvaceous woman in sight, or unleashing the Marquis de Sade into the fermenting hallways of an all girl's high school. But it wasn't. He was a man who came within reach of the top of the mountain, but only to have the rock he held loosen and he fell to the jagged bottom. With much prodding and forced encouragement, I would have to set the training wheels back on his bike and guide him along the cracked sidewalks of his frail confidence.

And I would do it. Wallbacher and I de-pantsed our sixth grade camp counselor, we hit spiraling fly balls behind our elementary school during summer vacations and we wore birthday hats strapped to our chins at each other's parties. History is too valuable to scrap over heart struck disillusionment. I would see him through it and I imagine he'd do the same. By the end of the night, when all the clowns huddle in groups at cacophonous bars, Wallbacher



The Recovery of Sunken Vessels

by
Ben Crites

During a period in late April when the birds' songs were seemingly more melodic and the glaze of sunshine inspired everyone to roost, my best friend Wallbacher was besieged by a transmogrifying lust for companionship. When his efforts fell short, he tortured himself in the face of unrequited love.

His phone call early that Saturday morning had unraveled me from the drowsy warmth of my beautifully petite girlfriend Samantha; my hand numb underneath her, strapped against her belly with the elastic of her panties.

Wallbacher spoke between long, contemplative silences, which he had done many times before when troubled by something. He spoke terse statements about nothing of consequence, keeping a safe distance from the underlying topic.

I felt my hand tingle, the blood rushing into it. Sam rolled over in the bed and I studied the curve of her spine while the cold tickled against my skin like a feather and goose bumps popped down my arms.

Sam moaned and rolled over in bed.

Why is it that as we age, we try to drift away from home? All of my friends were married or had fled to some distant town. I would not lose another.

I leaned against Wallbacher's front door, my hands full with my medical kit—a tray of two coffees and a couple Eclaires from Krispy Kreme. Juggling everything against the door, turned the knob, and pushed with my shoulders but the door jammed and the sudden halt splashed coffee down my Dockers.

"Shit," I said.

I shook the drops off of my hand and felt the skin tighten against the burn. I peered into the open gap of the front door. The Persian rug was draped over a large bulk, curled in the fetal position.

"Shit, man. What in the hell are you doing?" I said.

"Wipe your feet, please. I've just shampooed my carpet," Wallbacher said, his voice muffled under the rug.

Perhaps I should have been more compassionate and realized these words were spoken by a delirious man, but a red burn splotched across my fingers like a birthmark and the throb of it begged release. I stood on the hump and wiped my Asics thoroughly, digging my heels into the space between his ribs.

"Ouch, fuck, man," Wallbacher said standing up with the rug still draped over him like he was some hideous sculpting come to life. He removed the rug and a few hairs on his head erected from the static.

His apartment was clean; the carpet still had dark fan shapes impressed upon it. He had sustained serious damage, as evidenced by the Feng Shui implications of him balancing his surroundings, cleaning the burn marks of his scarred soul, removing all the clutter that cramped his chi. A war was waged on his coffee table; a chessboard set up, each king castled. Beside it lied a green bottle of Cabernet Sauvignon, a few bloody wine drops and a stained cork. There was an open bag of Mike Sells; its cavern held the rejected crumbs of a tired Wino.

"I think you broke a rib," Wallbacher said.

"Sorry, man. I got carried away."

anyone accessed my account: Pervert, conduct business quickly, do not make eye contact.

"What did you write?" I asked Wallbacher as we drove away.

"Nothing. Forget about it."

He slinked back into the seat and closed his eyes, seeking some dark retreat from another rejection. I imagined he wanted to recoil and start collecting bomb material and write manifestos against the government. Aren't all madmen, from Kacienzki to Bin Laden, just heart broken and insecure?

By this time it was obvious that the doctor needed help from another expert. I kept the car running, parked in the fire lane in front of Kroger's and I called Sam. It was great hearing her soft and raspy voice. I was sweet with her, garnering a further appreciation for her in light of the sad episodes of Wallbacher. I spoke to her in baby talk and sang into the receiver for a moment. Then I told her that I needed her help. She and a friend would meet us at a bar on the Ohio State University campus at 10:30 p.m. I expressed the urgency by which her friend must help sweep up the fragments of Wallbacher and put them back together.

I found myself punching Wallbacher on the arm a lot that day. Any suggestion of pessimism and he got one in the slope between his shoulder and triceps, right on the bone. Being in our twenties, I would warrant, posed an obstacle to the dating scene. Hell, hard as it was to believe, the frequency of embroidered wedding invitations was a bit frightening and weighed heavy on our social purpose. Working and dating was a difficult balance that many struggled with, but hell, why not take Wallbacher to the place where it was easy to score. Campus. The experiments of youth, away from home and living it up hard, were usually good opportunities to reap. This was where some kids dropped their guard to pot, mushrooms, blotter acid, or homosexual experiments. If they would be crazy enough to try these corrosives, surely they'd warm up to the woo of crazy Wallbacher.

I had spent most of my Saturday negating Wallbacher's dreadful arguments when I could have stayed in bed all day, ala John and Yoko, singing sweet music to my beloved Sam. But Wallbacher would have slipped further into the spiraling madness. These cases must be caught early before anything rash happens. I let him beat me in three games of chess, gradually building his confidence back up for the games to be had on campus.

That night I decided to drink coffee to keep tabs on Wallbacher because the potential of drunken catharsis seemed imminent and I meant to keep it in check. It was Folgers, the sludge that normally sat undisturbed on the burner for the designated drivers of a far off imaginary land. Here we careened off curbs and left mailboxes in shattered chunks. I

sipped at this sludge and smiled my big yellow teeth as Sam and her friend Karen traded their MED grievances and how tired it made them. Karen was garrulous, something that was intensified with the downpour of White Russians. She was dominating the conversation with medical acronyms and Wallbacher sat through it complacently for the second night straight. He was a jigsaw piece with creased edges, a piece of ostentatious dark sky in the middle of the brick building. Somewhere in the transition from college life to the work force, he had lost touch with his roots. Some women shot smiles across the dissipating patches of smoke and he'd give sheepish half-grins dreaming that the skin above their asses and on their ankles is uniform, not brandishing any tattoos of rose bracelets or their pagan names, I imagined.

It was something he complained about concerning campus girls. He seemed withdrawn, staring in the flickering glow of beer signs.

Bars have always been a platform for reminiscing. Old friends catch up on recent happenings, a mystery often perplexing and shameful. I felt jittery and tapped a sped up rhythm of "The Lion Sleeps Tonight" on the steel foundation under the table. The walls were lined with abstract paintings and they all had the same sad appeal, often the driving motivation behind art forms. My coffee mug was empty but I grabbed it and raised it to my lips dumbly as the habit would have it. I shopped around for a beautiful girl for Wallbacher. Everyone was preoccupied and it seemed we should have

chosen a meat market, but the girls wanted to talk now and the music of such places was deafening. Two beatniks hanging onto their pseudo-intelligent façade of drab clothing leaned over a chessboard. I overheard people at the table behind us discussing the values of disenfranchisement in Radiohead's OK Computer, which the juke kept coming back to as though it was being interrupted from listening to it in its entirety. Two guys at a table next to us postulated the possibilities of the bar maid being pregnant and the adverse effects of her smoking on James' Giant Peach inside of her. I remembered seeing her reading a mindless paperback behind the bar, something she could sacrifice to distraction, back when I frequented this joint a few years ago.

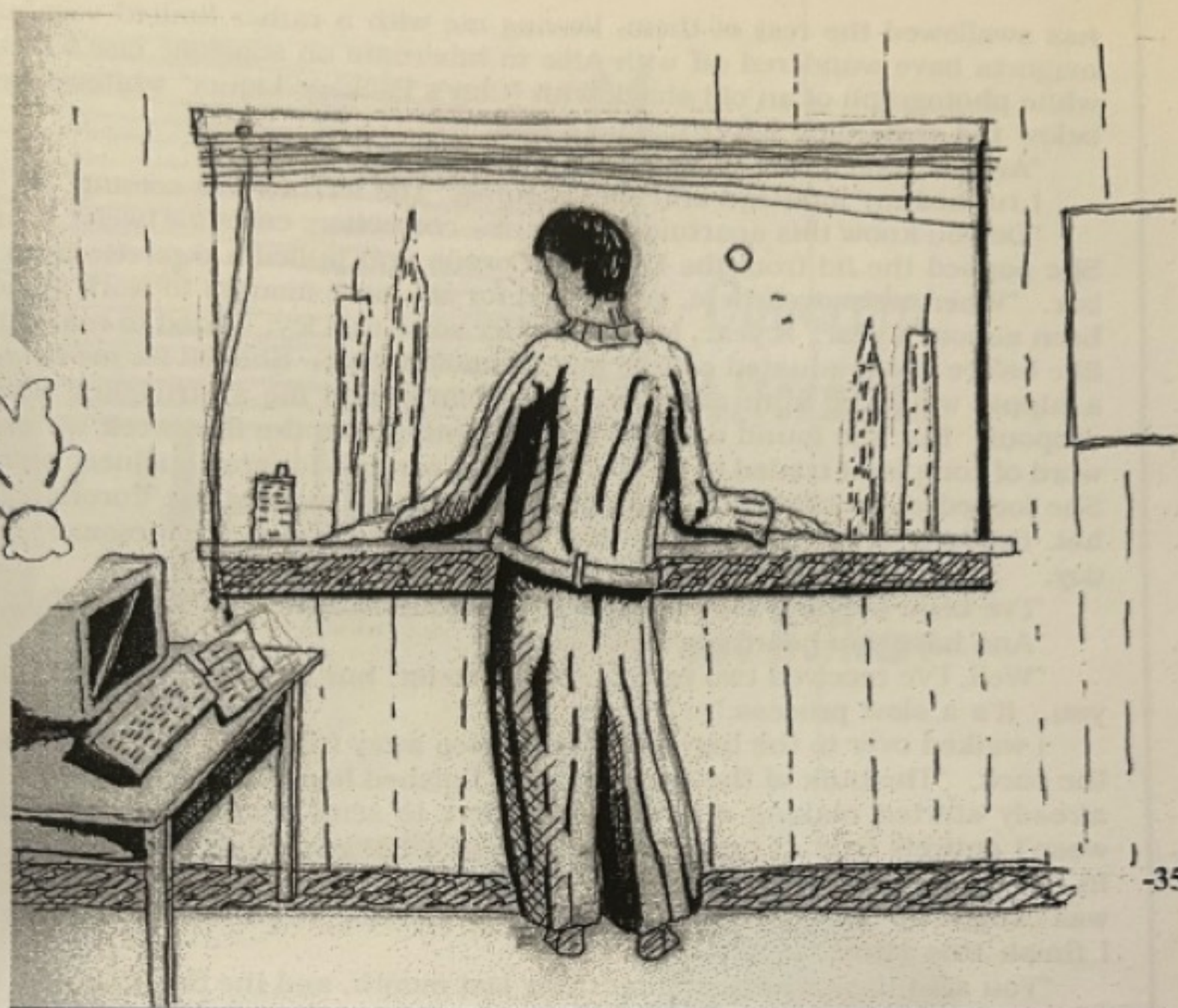
Another scruff bumped by us and smiled his joyful, inebriated smile. He was a blissful victim of a power hour, the shot-a-beer-a-minute (fuck it, let's get to the point, anything worth doing is worth doing right) hour of testimony, or so his loud blathering would have us believe. He wobbled in line to get another bottle; despondent after finding out none of us had any pot, and I picked up my empty mug and pressed it to my lips, again forgetting its vacuous nature.

I looked around the bar, at the three women lined up on stools and their legs crossed and limp feet kicking, and I thought forward to their toilet side attrition and the exorcism of the demonic Taco Bell. The bartender showed me



A Cover Letter

by
Shannon
Rampe



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It's been raining here for two weeks. I gaze out of my 14th floor apartment window at the Chicago sky, dark as a Leonard Cohen song. I guess the apartment is starting to stink. I haven't done laundry in over a month, and filthy clothes are strewn about the place. I haven't really noticed any smell yet—I quit bathing last Tuesday—but the pizza delivery boy nearly passed out yesterday when I opened my door. I think unholy things are growing in the sink, but I don't go near the kitchenette anymore. The garbage in there completely covers the floor and is pushing its way out onto the living room carpet. The tiny bedroom has been closed off for months, making me think of a Julio Cortazar story, "House Taken Over." I try to remember how this apartment looked when we first moved in, when Allie was still with me. I can't.

She left because of the housecoat. It was blue and tattered when we moved here, now it's little more than a threadbare sheet with sleeves that I wrap around my nakedness.

"My god Michael, when are you going to throw out that fucking housecoat?" she asked me one fateful Wednesday afternoon. There would be no sweet loving that hump day.

I shrugged and turned back to my computer screen, hovering over the keyboard and rubbing the corners of my lips. She picked up the remote control and muted the television. I had ceased paying attention to it hours ago, but now that the sound was missing, I noticed it. I swiveled my chair and frowned at her. "What." It wasn't a question. I knew she was mad about something, and this four-letter interrogative was my way of telling her that she had my attention. It was raining that day, I believe. A secret lake had filled up between us, and the dam broke.

She huffed and took a bottle of beer from the refrigerator. There were cute teddy bear magnets and fat letter magnets on the door, the kind you spelled out elementary words with when you were a kid. Now some of the letter magnets remain, currently spelling out "fuct this riter dog." This apartment

the ribs. She wore lime green scrubs. His eyes were pink on the edges and slightly bloodshot. He had been crying. His shirt had grass and mud stains on the lower back and on the elbows. My eye was swollen shut. They stopped about 15 yards away from me. Wallbacher scratched nervously at his head. The nurse looked around to see if anybody was watching. I looked down for a second. She walked over to the receptionist desk, leaned over the counter, and retrieved a pen. She pranced back over to him and blushed. Again, she looked to see if anyone was watching. Then she braced the cast across her arm and scribbled something on it, smiled and poked a dot on his nose with the pen. He reached out his good arm and shook the

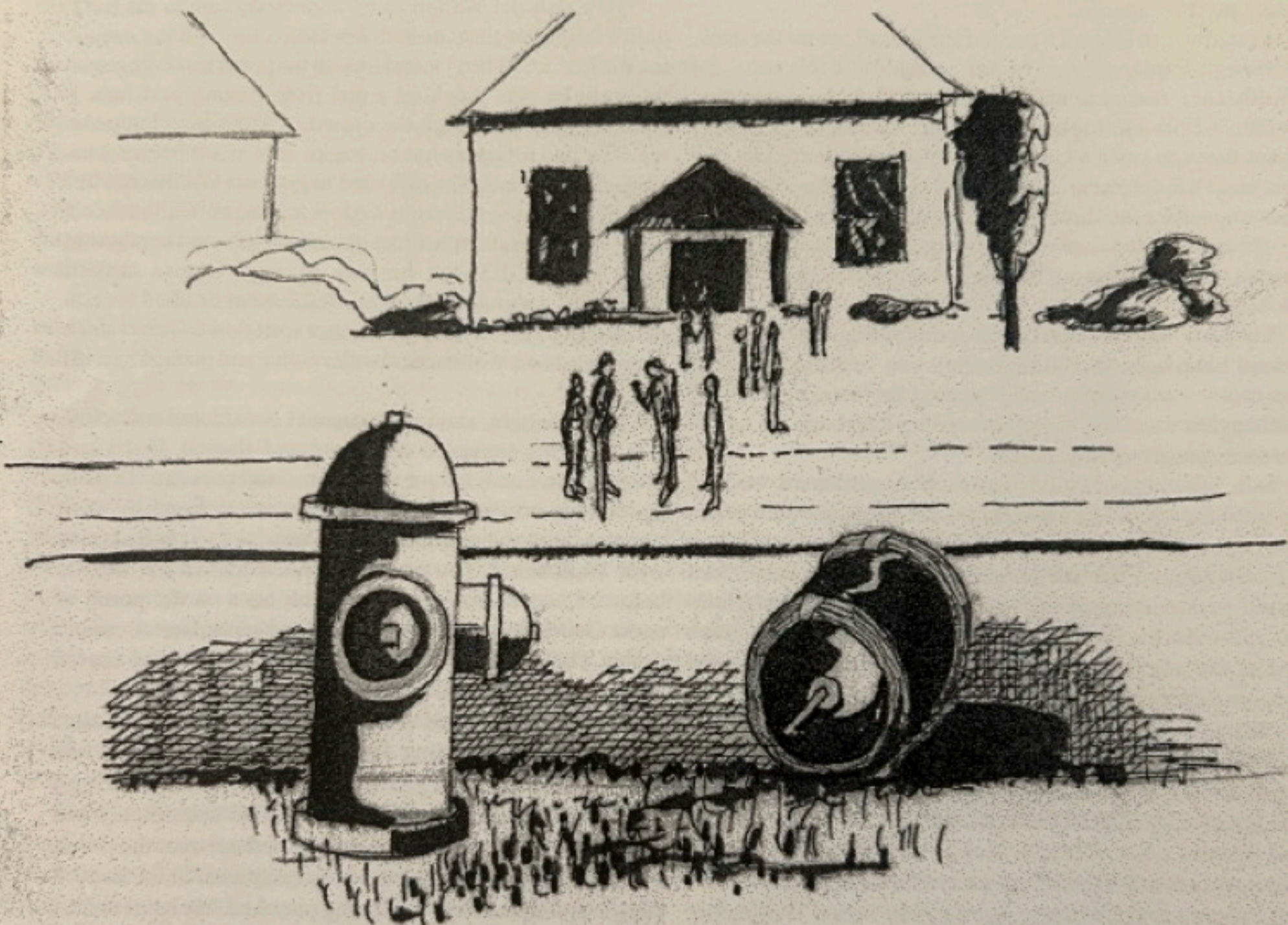
nurse's hand and held on for what seemed like forever. She let go and teetered on her heels for a moment while he nervously scratched the back of his head. Something must have really itched back there, I thought, then she turned and pranced through the emergency doors.

I stood up as he approached me, feeling a dull pain in my bruised hip.

"How are you feeling?" I asked.

"Better," he said and chuckled. I put my arm around him and he pulled me close and hugged me. We walked like that out into the calm of the dim April morning.

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sympathy, pouring out the sludge and brewing anew. I perused the bottle display behind him, the conical shaped Galliano, an almond flavored liquor from Italy, the green Midori melon liquor, some ambrosia for the men and women who will morph into Gods and Goddesses after the buzz takes hold. The bartender and I had warm conversations involving my thanks for the fresh coffee and him cutting the price in half on a refill. At the pool table behind me two flannel clad Hemingways compared the size of their Johnsons via the clamor of their breaks. The same girls lining the bar shot the same smiles through the curling screens of smoke and I sat back at the table, glad to not look so foolish when I went for my mug again, glad to have something warm to press my lips against.

I put my arm around Sam and she kissed me on the neck. Although I was warmed by the sensation, I felt sorry for Wallbacher, forced to witness the very thing he wanted but couldn't find. He looked down into the traces of bubbly foam that was once a Guinness, truly accepting the fact that this wasn't his element. I leaned across the table and prodded him to go after the three girls perched at the bar.

"I appreciate what you're trying to do," he yelled into my ear, "but I'm just not feeling it. It's been a long day." He looked at his watch.

The girls wanted to go dancing, and if I would have, Sam would have been incredibly happy and expressed it later, but cronies are cronies and I walked the creaking deck of Wallbacher's sinking vessel, brazening it through the tide of another somber voyage home.

Sam's fingers entwined in mine as we separated; we held on until the tips of our fingers brushed against each other. She had a silly beer buzzed smile on her face and when Karen triggered her car unlock with a double beep, Sam stared passionately at me and smiled. They stepped into the green Mazda, furthering their ventures at a dance club downtown where God knows what grisly Armani adorned men would grind against them to the staccato of bass rhythms.

Wallbacher walked with his head down, past the unkempt lawns littered with random wrappers, empty cigarette boxes, and paper bags. There were shards of broken beer bottles and dented cans splayed across the sidewalks. Some inebriated attention grabbers mocked us from a stoop, a lava lamp oozing in the window, but we didn't care. Wallbacher kicked a pebble and when he bridged the distance between it, he kicked it again with his hands stuffed in the pockets of his Haggis pants. He repeated this until the stone bounced into a divot in the dark lawn.

As I marched toward my Escort, headlights rushing past, I said something of little effect to Wallbacher about there being droughts in the fish pool, but he didn't reply and when I looked back toward where I expected him to be ambling, I saw nothing but a pizza box in the street. I turned around and saw him crossing about a hundred yards behind me. The hell, I thought.

He disappeared into a yard full of blonde girls in tight leggings and gold necklace wearing men, all holding flimsy plastic cups of beer. Some students wore Abercrombie vests and sports hats backwards. There was a discarded keg beside a fire hydrant. Moonlight gleamed on its silvery surface. A huge sheet hung out one of the windows of the house with three Greek letters written on it in shoe polish. It would be on fire before the night is over, I thought. A lot of things end up burning on campus. I remember seeing a futon ablaze in the middle of a street once. The thought of drunken college students and a canister of Zippo lighter fluid contributed to my overall spite towards campus, considering it a ruinous party ghetto.

"Hey asshole! Wait in line," somebody said to me but I didn't bother to turn around. I scanned through the crowd for Wallbacher. When I found him on the porch leaning against the wall, he was blocking a girl from getting past him. I pushed my way through the crowd. A kid with a Lacrosse tee shirt and a Gators hat on backwards stood behind him holding two beers. The girl tried to get past Wallbacher but he wouldn't let her through. Gators tapped on Wallbacher's shoulder, but Wallbacher just glanced at him and kept going on whatever diatribe he was giving. Gators tapped Wallbacher's shoulder again and Wallbacher brushed his arm off him aggressively and both beers spilt down Gators shirt. Gators grabbed Wallbacher by the collar and pushed him off the porch.

Fuck, I thought, and for a moment I considered collecting him from the trampled crabgrass and fleeing. But I had invested too much in him to go home and press an ice pack against his arm or leg. Friendships are defined by such threatening moments, and I was determined to cement mine with Wallbacher. Too many had been lost in the shuffle before. I needed somebody to drink beer on the porch of some God forsaken neighborhood and reminisce about old times. This would be another in the catalogue of shared experiences. The hell, I thought, into the breach.

The crowd hushed and watched us. I rammed Gators into the aluminum siding of the house and then struck him with a stiff right. The girl was crying. She was wearing a hospital personnel tag. Somebody pulled back on my hair and hit me square in the eye and pushed me over the porch. For moments, I didn't know where I was and felt the horrible sting and embarrassment of being punched. My heart rushed. Somebody grabbed me by my waistline of my pants and pushed me onto the sidewalk and kicked me in the back. I cut my hands on shards of glass.

Wallbacher's arm was all twisted. He was a block ahead of me yelling for me to follow him. I couldn't see out of my right eye. I scrambled for him, a horde of people cussing behind me. Wallbacher's legs shook and I wrapped his good arm around my shoulder and we hobbled to the Escort and drove in silence to the University hospital.

Wallbacher limped through the emergency doors with a nurse. She was smiling and joking with him, elbowing him in

has swallowed the rest of them, leaving me with a rather limited vocabulary. The teddy bear magnets have wandered off with Allie to hibernate on someone else's fridge door. A black and white photograph of an old shack with "Clay's Package Liquor" whitewashed on the side is taped below the remaining letter-magnets now.

"Are you ever going to look for a job?" she asked.

I rubbed my forehead and said nothing. The lecture was coming.

"Do you know this apartment costs us—correction: costs *me* twelve hundred bucks a month?"

She popped the lid from the bottle of Corona and pulled a cigarette from the pack lying on the bar. "When we moved here, you asked for six more months to work at home. I said okay. It's been almost a year. A year, Michael." Her voice was icy. I tried to remember what she had been like before she graduated college and we moved here. She fell for me because I am a writer, she a hippie wannabe from an upper class family and me a struggling writer and an art school dropout. But she found a job at an accounting firm the first week we were here and without a word of complaint traded in her tie-dyes and sandals for gray business suits and sensible pumps. She looked authoritatively sexy glaring at me and sipping the Corona. I felt my cheeks turn hot, thinking of all those successful, well-dressed young businessmen she lunched with every day.

"I've been sending out a bunch of my short stories."

"And have you heard anything back?"

"Well, I've received two rejection slips so far, but it takes awhile for magazines to get back to you. It's a slow process."

I walked over to the bar. She took a step away from me. I frowned and took a cigarette from the pack. "The bulk of the manuscript is finished honey. Pretty soon, I'll be done editing it. I've already started making a list of publishers to send it to. I just need another month." This wasn't entirely true. I hadn't actually written the ending yet. I was still waiting for it to hit me. In the meantime, I had set some incredible records playing Minesweeper and Solitaire. Also, I was caught up on all my soap operas. Still, the end was on its way. I'm finishing it tonight, after I finish this letter.

"You said the same goddamn thing last month, and the month before that! Last month, you promised to start sending out some résumés. I even went through the newspaper for you and circled job listings! You haven't done a goddamn thing, have you?"

Had I stopped to think about it, I probably would have felt ashamed of myself. I had been mooching off my fiancé for nearly a year! My sole form of income had been when my mom mailed me a check for \$200 on my birthday, and another one for Christmas. My ego was bruised though, and I yelled at her. "What am I supposed to do? Sacrifice my creative spirit to the burger consuming throngs of McDonalds' cretins? She yelled back. We yelled together, our last shared experience. Then she left.

I shiver and wrap my housecoat tighter around me. The gas company shut off the heat over the weekend. I rub the corners of my mouth. There are sores there now. I look around the floor. Scattered amidst the gray socks and jeans and stained t-shirts are dozens of slips of paper. This one says Orion Review. That one says Wondrous Stories Unlimited. Some are big. Some are small. Some are handwritten, but most are photocopies. They are all form letters. I pick one up and read it. "*Thank you for submitting to Delta Strife Tales. We're sorry, but we felt that your manuscript was not right for our magazine. Thank you for submitting and good luck placing your piece elsewhere.*" Rejection tastes thick and bitter, like the pot of coffee I've been nursing for the last three days.

Anyway, enjoy the read. I haven't included an SASE, since I won't be here to receive the rejection slip. I've got a long trip ahead of me: 14 floors.

Sincerely,

Michael Davidson
Encl.



Concrete Afternoon

by
Joe Bellomy

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It is a hot concrete afternoon.

I clutch the syringe and move away from him. I've just closed his eyes and have already wept.

For him the end was clear. For him, everything had been clear. What power that must have brought. I look at the syringe. The clear liquid within jiggles as my hand trembles. Thomas is dead. It's over.

The afternoon glare breaks through the filthy window leaving the room without shadow. I press myself against the far wall, squeezing the needle. I am not sad. Not for myself. Not for Thomas. What had it all come to? For Thomas, peace. For myself, a quiet suicide in a hot dry box?

Thomas had been beautiful, alive with an energy that could crackle from his fingertips and bristled his hair. Even now he was beautiful. How old was he? Twenty, twenty-two?

In Virginia there is love and everything is born of love.

"I'll wait for you," Thomas was on his knees, his thin blond hair pulled away from his face. "Trust me Linda. Don't fail me Linda. I love you."

How warm his touch was. How soft his kisses. How trusting. How seductive.

-38- In Ohio there is peace, clean gauze clothing and fresh productive gardens. The group works.

His eyes burned fiercely blue below his smooth clear forehead. As he raged his small compact body bound itself into tight hard knots. "Trust me with your life young girl. Trust me with your bloated body and starving soul. Trust me with everything you possess and I will show you freedom." As he spoke, as he stood, as he breathed, I lived. Fear was nothing next to love and I loved him. Thomas/love.

In LA there is sex and surrender. The group is one.

This room has no furniture. We are all here. It's a solid block of frozen air. We sit around him. We hallucinate. We make love. We do not eat. We do not sleep. I am Linda. The others here love him also, as they should. He is sleeping now and we wait and we dream.

In this room I am naked and cold. I cannot breath. I am choking, dying. My eyes begin to bleed. I cover them with my hands and they fill with blood. I rub my face and it becomes smooth and featureless.

His hands are soft and smooth and he strokes my brow, comforts me. He is so beautiful. Thomas/savior.

In Frisco, hunger and tears and anger.

He stands before us. His nude body white, smooth, shimmering. The knife he holds moves through the air and digs into his left wrist. But he isn't hurt. The wound erupts and blood flows to the floor. He wraps it with a cloth and puts the blade to his other wrist.

In the van we travel silently. It holds us five easily. Joseph, who was afraid, we give courage. Sally, who was lost, has been found. Timothy drives and speaks only to Thomas. I am Linda and Thomas loves me.

In Kansas there is death.

Thomas/Love. Thomas/Savior. Thomas/God.

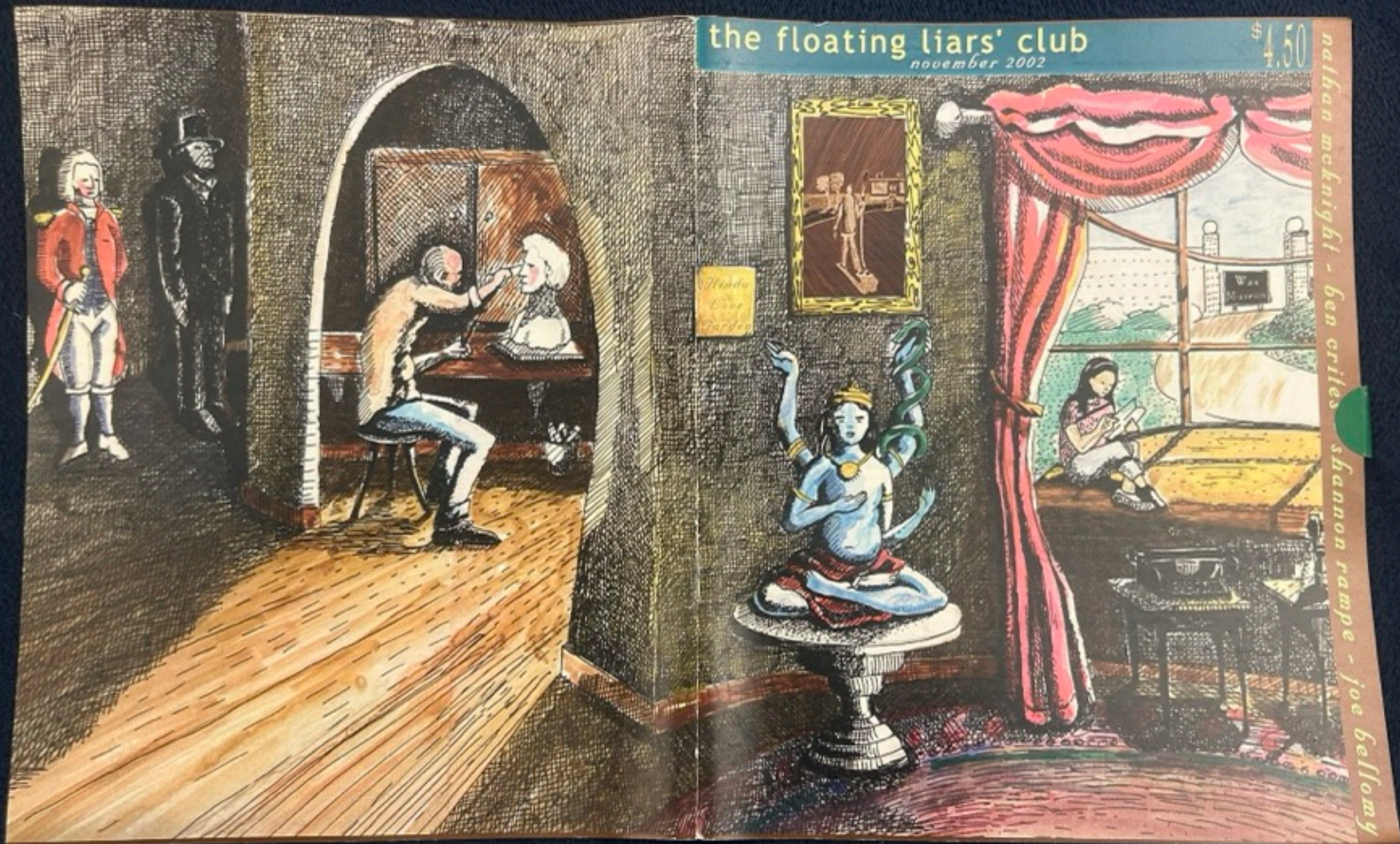
We are starving and Thomas tells us we must find Joseph who has run away. He cannot be far because he has no money. We search and search. Why have you left us Joseph?

I wait outside as Timothy goes in. We need money and food. I hear the scream and it frightens me. I go inside and see the child run to the stair. Timothy is close behind. He strikes the child across the head and it tumbles down the steps. Timothy grunts like an animal. I am sick and leave the house.

On the bed Thomas is cold though the room is hot. I take off my cloths and lie next to him. I shiver. I am to follow him but the syringe falls to the floor.

It's a hot concrete afternoon. The sidewalk burns my feet. The sun burns my naked skin. I see the men coming toward me. Their chests flashing beams of sunlight. Their heavy black belts flopping as they run. I'm held and pulled into a car. Joseph's here, his wrists bound, his face buried in his hands.



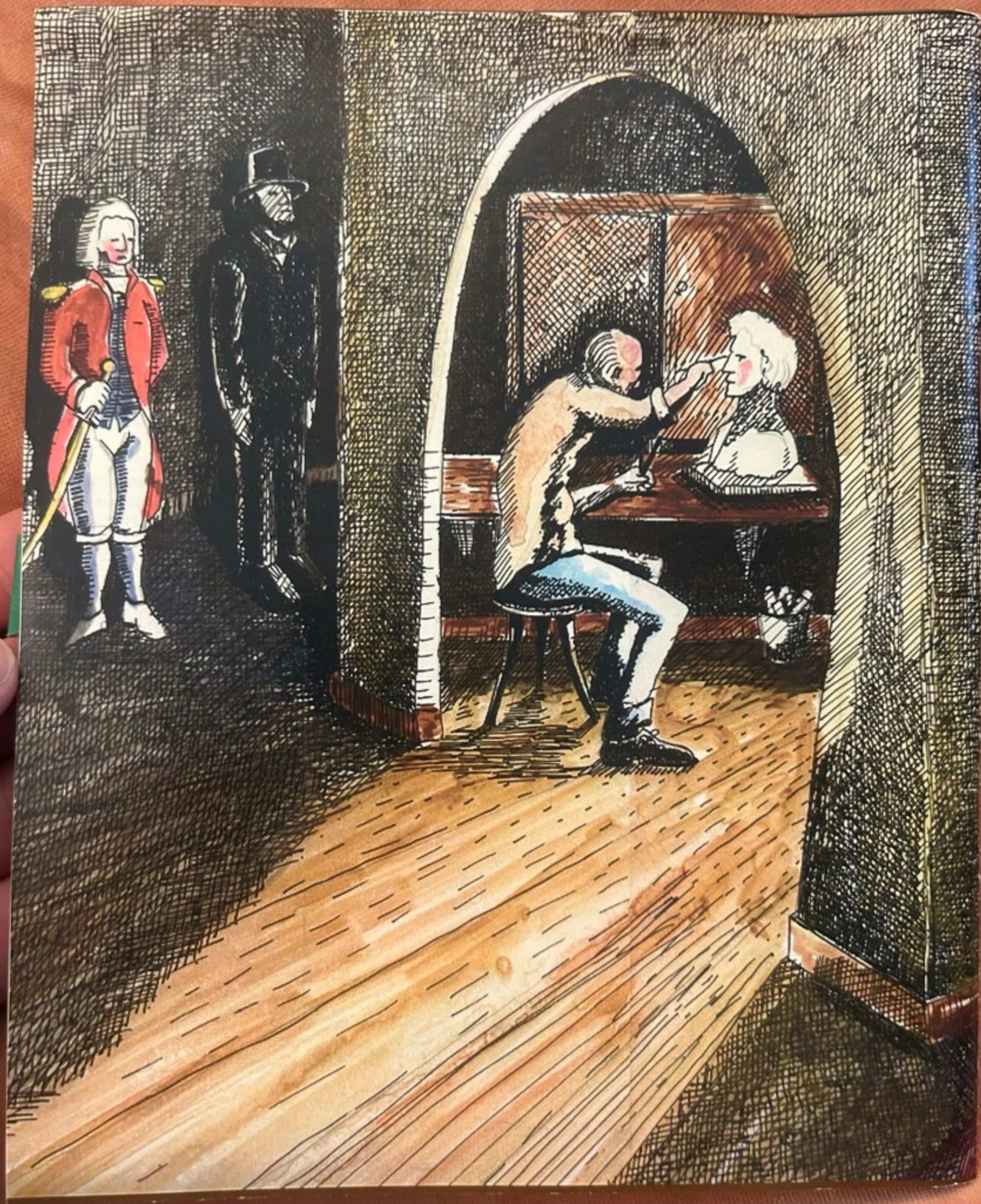


the floating liars' club

november 2002

\$4.50

nathan mcknight - ben criles shannon rampe - joe bellomy



about the contributors

This is a writers' magazine.

All story rights are property of the contributor, as is all praise and blame.

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Joseph Bellomy

echoterra183@cs.com was born in this place without knowing why. Has had a particular language imposed upon him along with particular ideas. Has often wondered, wandered, and wobbled. Has jumped in a lake, gone and flown a kite, and taken many flying leaps.

Benjamin Crites

Ben Crites received his B.F.A. in 1999 from Bowling Green State University. He currently resides in Columbus where he is a journalist. Ben can be reached at ben_crites@yahoo.com

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Nathan McKnight

Nathan's been trying to make a magazine for longer than he's been seriously writing fiction...which is sad, really. His stories have been rejected from various reputable publications, but firmly believes he will be published on the twenty-first attempt. The secret to good pumpkin pie is fresh pumpkin and Chinese five spice. aelffin@hotmail.com

Shannon Rampe

Shannon fancies himself a writer and is curious to talk writing or philosophy with anyone who is interested. he can be found smoking cigarettes in the back parking lot of the Lane Avenue Half Price Books. He would like to thank his friends and family for supporting him, especially Lauren, Jim Bowsher, and the Eveningland Writers' Group. Contact him at rampsputant@yahoo.com

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